

DON'T  
CALL IT  
THAT:  
A NAMING  
WORKBOOK  
BY  
ELI ALTMAN

THIRD  
EDITION

Front Matter

To Brian Scott—for getting me into this publishing mess to begin with.

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**Welcome to the third edition of  
Don't Call It That.**

So glad you could join me.

I'm humbled by the demand for this book. When the second edition sold out it would have been a lot easier to just reprint it, but that would have been a missed opportunity. It might not surprise you to find out that when I'm not writing books, I'm working on naming projects—lots and lots of naming projects. Every project has its own challenges and opportunities because creativity, and communication for that matter, is impossible to master. Working on lots of projects gives me opportunities to test ideas and see what develops better names, and better ways of sharing them. Since the second edition of the book came out in November 2016, the team at A Hundred Monkeys has worked on just over 200 naming projects. We've learned a lot (it would have been hard not to). So when I finally took a fresh look at Don't Call It That, I wanted to make sure it included everything I've figured out and put into practice since 2016. It turns out, putting the book together has been a really useful way to codify what I've learned. I hope it's useful for you too.

So, here's what's new in the third edition of Don't Call It That:

—————> **More to love:** The third edition has 62% more content than the second—no minor rewrite here.

—————> **Real project examples:** I included several real-life examples from A Hundred Monkeys projects throughout the book.

—————> **Client experiences:** I also included quotes directly from clients to shed light on how new names are perceived and adopted.

—————> **New Chapters:** There are three entirely new chapters on market testing names, the near-universal desire for short names, and the difference between how names look and how they sound.

—————> **New look:** The book has been completely redesigned by the fine folks at Moniker.

—————> **New editor:** The third edition has been edited by long-time collaborator Rose Linke, an experienced writer, editor, and namer in her own right. We even included a few of our chat transcripts from the editing process.

—————> **Six new name species:** Wordsmash, Rhyme time, Opposites attract, That's not my name, Unlikely allies, and Simple enough.

—————> **Overhauled exercises:** The book's exercises have been totally reworked. There are several new exercises as well as updates to previous exercises.

—————> **Minor restructuring:** The chapters "Ready, set" and "Get to the point" from the second edition have been combined into a more holistic chapter on positioning called "Condition your position."

## This edition contains:

|    |                                    |
|----|------------------------------------|
| 01 | Aim for the eyes                   |
| 02 | A bad place to start               |
| 03 | Condition your position            |
| 04 | Jumping through hoops              |
| 05 | Make some headroom                 |
| 06 | The attention deficit              |
| 07 | Show don't tell                    |
| 08 | Wordsmash                          |
| 09 | Kids, dogs, goldfish               |
| 10 | I'm with stupid                    |
| 11 | Don't reinvent the wheel           |
| 12 | Short changing yourself            |
| 13 | Hear say                           |
| 14 | The power of isolation and context |
| 15 | New species discovered daily       |
| 16 | Apples to alligators               |
| 17 | Love at first sight                |
| 18 | Names are living beings            |
| 19 | How to ask friends                 |
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| 21 | Climbing over clichés              |
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| 23 | Field exercise                     |
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How names make our lives easier

When you were in grade school, some librarian probably told you not to judge a book by its cover. Then they probably went on to tell you how you shouldn't judge people by their proverbial covers because we're all so deep and complex. Seems like good enough advice, right?

The only problem is, everyone judges books by their covers. We have to.

The psychology behind this is pretty basic. We're constantly bombarded by tons of advertising and marketing to the point where we're not mentally equipped to pay attention to everything that ends up in front of our two little eyes. This is especially true for brands. If you had to catalog every brand you came upon in a single day, it would be an all-consuming task. The world is saturated with brands, and, as a result, advertisers get excited when two percent of the exposed audience responds actively—for example, clicking on an ad, retweeting, or Like-ing a Facebook post.

Dr. Martin Hilbert of the University of California at Davis works on calculating the amount of information humans process. He estimates we're bombarded by the equivalent of 174 entire newspapers worth of data every single day. This represents a fivefold increase since 1986.

The result is some mental triage. We subconsciously set up simple tests to take small amounts of surface-level information, like what a company is called and how it looks, in order to instantaneously decide whether it's worth paying attention to.

We pay attention to the information that catches our attention. It's a coping mechanism for the all-out marketing blitz we face every day of our lives. If we didn't develop a way to figure out what's worth paying attention to, we'd spend hours in the toothpaste aisle at the grocery store comparing anti-cavity claims.

With such a small window to catch someone's attention, what you call yourself becomes incredibly important. This need is amplified for new companies and products. You only have so much time to show people you're gaining traction before the cash dries up. It's hard to gain traction if people can't remember what you're called. Your name is typically the first thing anyone will come in contact with. It's your first impression. Do you want your first impression with your audience to be something that's cool and interesting and helps you tell your story? Or do you want it to be something that sounds like everything else and gets ignored?

In 2015 my team at A Hundred Monkeys worked with a small startup called Portal who was building an easy-to-install home Wi-Fi system. At the time, router names seemed to cluster around one naming approach. Let's see if you can spot what it is. These are the top 10 Wifi routers of 2015:

TP-LINK TL-WR841N  
 ASUS RT-N66U  
 TP-LINK TL-WR940N  
 ARRIS / Motorola SURFboard SBG6580  
 NETGEAR Nighthawk AC1900  
 NETGEAR RangeMax WNR1000  
 ASUS RT-AC68U  
 ASUS RT-AC66U  
 TP-LINK Archer C7  
 NETGEAR Nighthawk X6 AC3200

The common denominator here is blindingly obvious. Standing out requires little more than avoiding alphabet soup. These names also sound overly technical and complex—like they're designed to attract your IT department. This fits in with the narrative that Wi-Fi networks are difficult to setup and maintain. We wanted a name that felt effortless and simple because that was the promise of the product. We landed on Eero. No numbers or letters afterwards. Just Eero. Compare that to the names above. Looking at the lists of best routers now you can see

that many companies followed Eero's lead (Netgear Orbi, TP-Link Deco, ASUS Blue Cave...) but not before Eero could establish a dominant and differentiated market position. The company ended up being acquired by Amazon in 2019.

“From the name down to the design of the site, the product and the user experience. The sweeping form of the top of the device, the nice clean lines—it's all influenced by Eero.”

—Eero founder Nick Weaver

Since a name is a very compact, easy-to-communicate piece of information, a good name can grab people's attention instantly. A good name can make people want to dive in and learn more. It can also make people smile or laugh. When people say they get business through “word of mouth,” what's actually being passed from person to person? The name. Names are the only aspects of brands that can easily be communicated verbally.

To get you into the process of naming things, I've structured this book as a series of exercises. The exercises lead from one to the next. It's hands-on for a reason. There's a difference between studying art

history and studying art. That is to say, this book isn't about the theory or philosophy behind naming. It's about the process of naming and how to come up with great names.

—————→ Heads up

When I read through my first draft of this book, I realized that I had referred to products, companies, brands, and services interchangeably. In most cases they all function similarly, so just because an example features a product, doesn't mean the lesson won't work for a company.





“One of the things that frustrates me and that people don’t appreciate is that there are so many bad movies. You have to have some feeling about how bad a movie can be before you can appreciate the good ones.”

–Andrew Sarris

So let's start with something pretty simple. Write down the idea behind your brand in one sentence or phrase. Don't overthink it. Maybe it's an upscale ice cream truck or intuitive video editing software or yoga for veterans. If it doesn't come to you right away, try a few things and see what feels the most distinct.

[illegible]

Now, come up with 15 or so really bad names for your project. If we're doing upscale ice cream, maybe something like:

**iScream**

## Premium Ice Cream, Inc.

## Cream of the Ice

## Not Popsicles

## Cold Cream

## Cream & Cone

## 32 Flavors

## Flavorz Extreme

## Iced Creme

## Cremertaw

You get the picture.

→ Exercise

Come up with 15 or so “bad” names:

This image shows a full page of dot grid paper. The background is white, and it is covered with a regular pattern of small, dark grey dots. The dots are arranged in straight horizontal and vertical lines, creating a grid-like appearance. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the page.

Now, write down why each name is bad.

**Premium Ice Cream, Inc.:**

Zzzzzzzzz

**iScream:**

Get sued by Apple.  
People will spell it wrong.  
Feels too sterile.

**Cold Cream:**

Sounds like an ointment from the drug store.

**32 Flavors:**

Baskin-Robbins shouldn't mind.

We're starting with bad names for a few reasons. Primarily, it's a lot easier to think of bad stuff than good stuff. If you set the bar super low, it's easy enough to hop right over. Additionally, figuring out what makes names bad is a good place to start thinking about what makes names good. Flip the switch on the bad attributes of these names, and you start to get some qualities you might want to focus on.

So let's look at why bad names are bad:

—————> **They're descriptive:** Unless you're doing something truly compelling, having a name that describes what you do is a guaranteed way to make sure people

never pay attention to you. An example I like to use is the airline, AirTran. They do transportation... in the air... fascinating. Sure they might be a successful company, but their name is sleep-inducing, hard to remember, and says absolutely nothing about their point of view. Then again, AirTran had a good reason for a bland name—it wanted to fly under the radar after ditching its previous name, ValuJet, following a 1996 crash in Florida.

What are some other descriptive names? General Electric, Whole Foods, Grocery Outlet, General Motors, Bank of America, United Postal Service

At this point you might be saying: "Wait! These are hugely successful companies with big brands. I would love to have a brand like Whole Foods or UPS!" To this I say: you aren't going to beat or even compete with these brands by sounding like them. Because these brands with descriptive names are well established, people are clear about the service or product on offer. What do you have to gain by re-asserting that with a similar name? Also, most of these brands were established so long ago that they could actually stake a legal claim to something as large as "General Electric" or "Bank of America." In case you haven't noticed, the world is a lot more competitive these days.

Simply put, using your name to describe what you do is a wasted opportunity.

—————→ **They try to encompass everything:** A lot of people take the desire to not pigeonhole themselves way too far and avoid showing any personality whatsoever. Being overly general leads to boring names that have nothing to do with your specific proposition. This is why so many companies say they're in the "solutions business." Anything can be construed as a solution: Waste Management Solutions, Business Intelligence Solutions, Container Solutions. The point is, picking a name that "doesn't rule anything out" generally doesn't draw anyone in either.

—————→ **They don't mean anything:** This is a fun one. Lots of people (particularly those who prioritize short URLs) like to name their companies after whatever short string of letters has an available dot com. When naming, it's best to play off of connections people already have in their heads. This way, when they hear your name, a picture will appear, which will help with recall. When you pick a name that means absolutely nothing, it's hard for your audience to make the connection to what you're doing or how you feel about the world around you. It's easier to lump your brand in with all the other brands named after nothing—that is, if anyone can

remember your random string of letters at all. Sure, with enough marketing dollars you can get someone to remember a word you invented. Big companies coin names when they care more about protecting a brand than inviting people in. To me, that money is better spent elsewhere.

—————→ **They're boring:** See "names that are descriptive," "names that try and encompass everything."

—————→ **They're on trend:** Trends come and go. When the trend inevitably ends, your name will be frozen in time. Lots of cool restaurants these days have Blank & Blank names like Bourbon & Beef, Fork & Vine, Salt & Time, Wolf & Hound. When everyone moves onto the next trend, these names will start to look old. Great names should be timeless—not dying to fit in with a passing trend. How many people are dropping vowels like Tumblr and Flickr these days?



### Condition your position

Good names know what they're doing

Naming becomes a lot easier when you have an objective—one thing you want the name to communicate. When you have an objective, it's easy to see past all the shallow criticism and find a name that gets the job done. The objective can really be anything, but a good place to start is: What do I want my audience to feel when they hear my name? Now, this isn't such an easy question. The answer needs to set you apart. The answer represents the kernel of your positioning.

Recently we were lucky enough to work on a project naming a supersonic passenger jet for Boom Supersonic alongside design partners Manual Creative. From a naming perspective, this was an interesting challenge. The vast majority of passenger jets are produced by two companies and named alphanumerically—737, 787, A330, A380. Only two supersonic jets have ever flown commercially, the famed Concorde and the lesser known Russian Tupolev Tu-144. Both have been out of service for years. Peripherally there were also supersonic military aircraft to consider: Hornet, Falcon, Eagle, Lightning, Raptor. Fast, powerful, and something we wanted to steer clear of.

Working with the leadership team at Boom we were clear that speed wasn't the answer. The question became: speed

in the service of what? The plane lets you take trips that you wouldn't have considered before. People don't think about air travel in terms of miles and kilometers. They think about it in terms of hours. With this plane cutting many international flight times in half, the effect is bringing the world closer together. New York to London and back becomes an easy day trip. The name *Overture* was an immediate favorite with the team. In music, an overture is an introduction. Boom is introducing a new plane and reintroducing supersonic travel to airline passengers. The name also has "over" in it, subtly signaling it will literally be 30,000 feet over traditional jetliners.

Getting clear on what we wanted to communicate with the name made evaluating names much easier for everyone involved. We all have our own likes and dislikes. The positioning and objectives helped the team get beyond their personal tastes to focus on what the name would mean to their broader audience.

Positioning is the art of showing people how you're different—what you do that your competitors don't. This difference can be physical (Dyson vacuums don't lose suction, Freitag bags are made of used truck tarpaulins) or it can take your

mind somewhere unique (*Cards Against Humanity* lives on a different planet than *Uno*, *Go Fish* and *Crazy Eights*). It can be a difference in product, audience, attitude, anything. This isn't a book on positioning, per se, but knowing how you want to set yourself apart from the competition can certainly set the stage for a great name.

For example, if you sell luxury watches you probably want to communicate that they're expertly crafted, precise, Swiss-made, that sort of thing. The problem is, all luxury watch brands say this. Now, you can join Rolex and Breitling and try to beat them at their own game, but you're probably going to lose—they've been at this a long time and it's going to be hard to unseat them saying the same things they're saying. Besides, their marketing budgets are likely much bigger than yours.

Thinking about names without first establishing your positioning is like selecting a box before buying the present that'll go in it. It's a decision without context.

—————→ **Important:** Avoid trying to say you're the best, greatest, fastest, or most reliable at anything. These claims are better experienced than said. It might be true, but people are so used to hearing it, they aren't going to believe you. Also, while you

might be the best or fastest when you go to market, the competition catches up. Names are supposed to last the life of your business. These claims are temporary at best and outright lies at worst.

“If they give you lined paper,  
write the other way.”

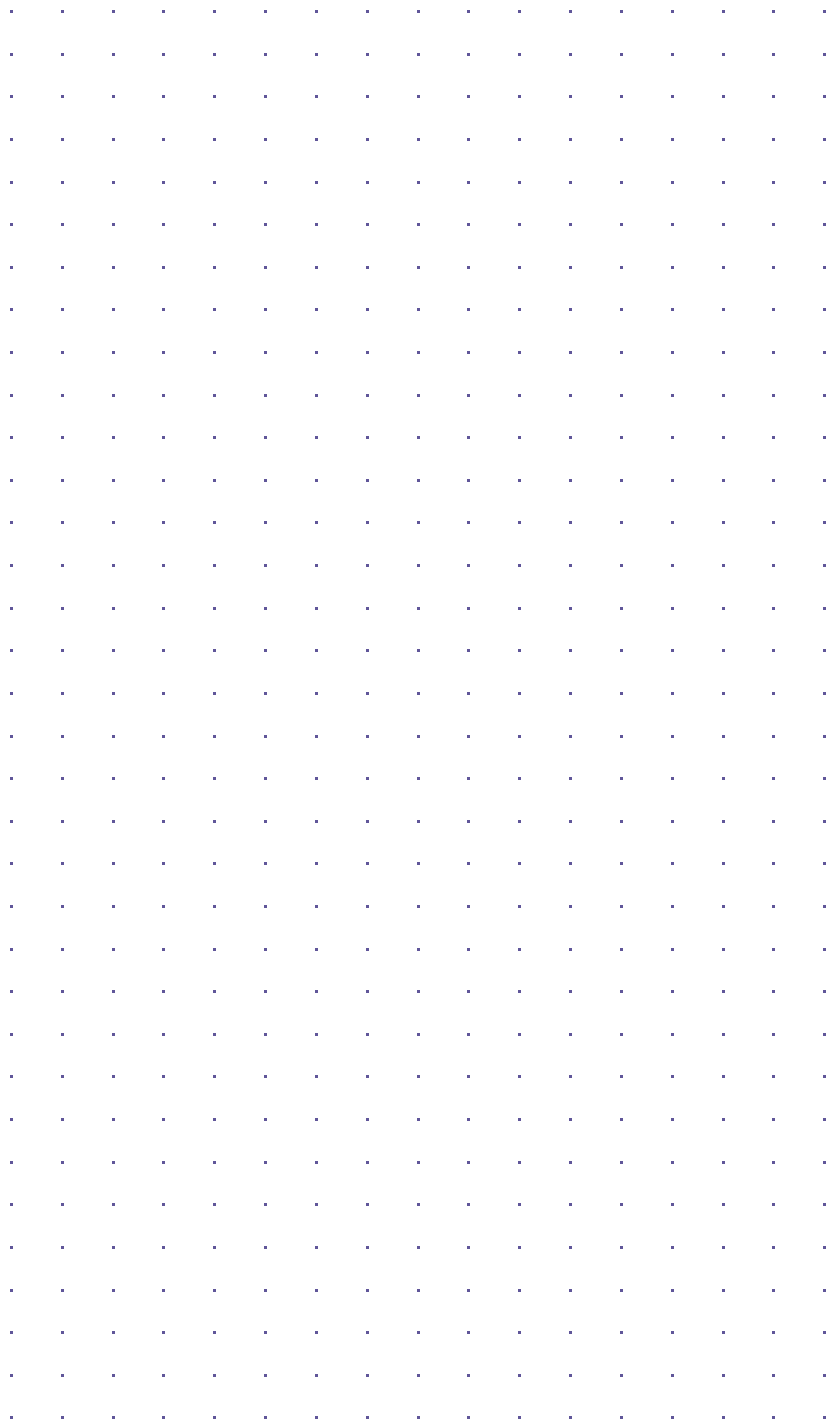
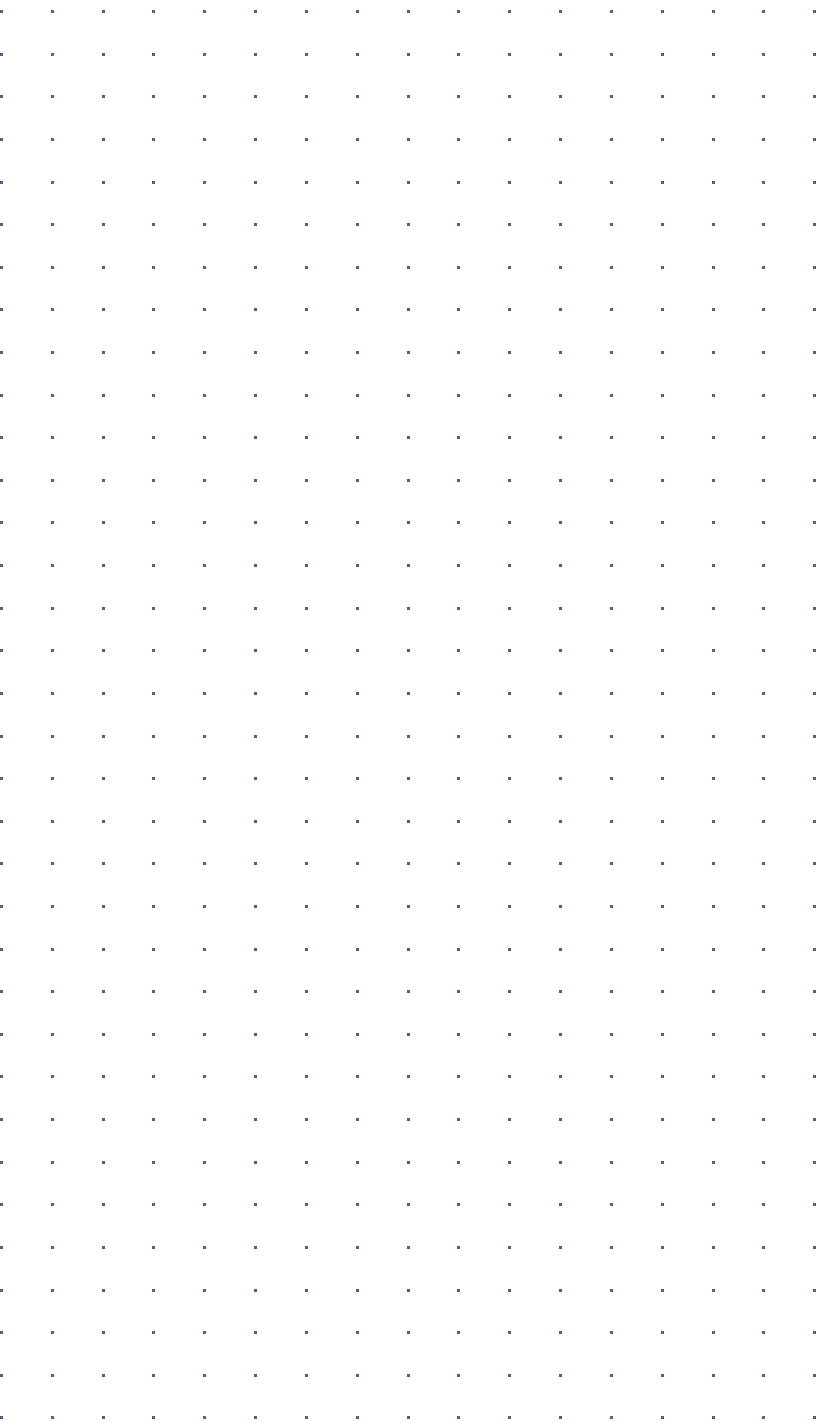
–William Carlos Williams

Start thinking of some feelings and ideas you want your name to communicate. How do you want to be different from your competition? How can you signal that with your name? Look at outdoor apparel company Arc'teryx as an example. A lot of outdoor apparel companies try to evoke the mountains: The North Face, Mountain Hardware, Patagonia, Sierra Designs. Arc'teryx, short for Archaeopteryx, makes you think of digging and paleontology. It's still about the outdoors, but decidedly different than its mountaineering contemporaries.

## Exercise

- What are your competitors' names?
- What do they have in common as names?
- What are some names that would stand out next to these competitors?
- What are some names that make it clear you see the world differently?

Write down how you want to position your brand. Is your positioning differentiated? Will it stand the test of time?







So we’ve established that names are better when they have an objective that fits in with your brand’s positioning. Notice that I said objective not objectives. A lot of people like to put a bunch of requirements in place before they start coming up with names. Not only does this make finding a good name a needle-in-a-haystack exercise, most of these requirements aren’t well founded. Let’s look at a few of the most common barriers people erect to make naming more complicated than it has to be:



**Pronounceability and spell-ability:**

A lot of people want names that are edgy, imaginative, and inimitable, but only so long as they’re also easy to spell, easy to say, and impossible to forget. The only trouble being, easy and evocative are natural enemies. Nothing is so sure to slip between the ears undetected as the word that requires no effort to absorb. As a counter-example, there’s a mexican restaurant in San Francisco I used to frequent when I worked there called Tlaloc. Is it hard to pronounce? Yes. Is it hard to spell? Definitely. Did I spend a bunch of time looking at and saying the name? Absolutely. I still say it sometimes just for fun. Try it. Tlaloc.

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**Descriptive:**

Often people are afraid that if their name doesn't have a clear connection to what they're doing, no one will ever figure it out. A quick survey of popular brands disproves this idea quite effectively.

We remember best that which asks something of us. So, embrace the difficult, the strange, the bizarre. And if you want people to remember you, embrace the one thing that will help them do just that: standing out. There's no point in coming up with a name that makes you sound like everyone else and then spending a bunch of money on marketing trying to convince people you're different. A good name can do the work for you, but only if you let it.

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**URL:**

Look, we all know it's hard to find a straightaway dot com. This means that most people who spend any time on the internet are pretty tolerant and forgiving when it comes to URLs. Not everyone needs a URL as pure as the driven snow. While clearly the first choice is to have yourbrandname.com, its unavailability should almost never be a dealbreaker. A lot of people get caught looking for a URL instead of a name. Don't join their ranks. First you need to think about how your core audience will end up at your website. Will you speak with them first? Will they see you in an online banner ad? Will they search for you on Google? In most of these cases, they won't be directly typing your URL into the browser—they'll have some help. Auto-complete goes a long way. So do links. Even if your brand exists entirely online, most people will be getting to your site through search engines and other links. Modern browsers like Firefox and Chrome include search in the address bar making it even easier to find where you're trying to go.

## → Heads up

If people want to find you, chances are they will (even if you're a startup). You probably shouldn't be focusing too much attention on the sort of consumer who gives up on finding you after yourbrandname.com doesn't take them to the right place.

Even if your brand does exist exclusively on the internet, you're probably better off finding a strong name that grabs people's attention, and then finding a URL that works. If you're confident in what you're doing and how you're doing it, having a slightly modified URL won't be a big obstacle for you.

There are thousands of very successful brands that use dot net or some other prefix, suffix, or creative URL extension. As long as the dot com isn't a big or related business, another domain extension is a viable option. Some people think that if you don't have a dot com, customers will think you don't have a serious business. To them I say that a URL isn't the only way to show people you have a serious business. Having a well-designed site certainly helps, and so does a little publicity. Some very successful sites that didn't worry about having a dot com include wordpress.

org, bit.ly, angel.co, rapha.cc, good.is, behance.net, and Google's parent company Alphabet (abc.xyz). Again, if people are using a search engine to find you, having a dot net isn't a big deal. In the case of Good, they used the country extension for Iceland in their URL. In many cases you don't have to do business in a country in order to use their extensions and you can create some pretty interesting options that have a good shot at being available. Other potentially useful extensions are: .as, .at, .be, .by, .co, .ee, .in, .it, .ly, and .to. You can view all of them here: [ahundredmonkeys.com/dcit](http://ahundredmonkeys.com/dcit).

In the end, searching for pure URLs is a losing battle. The number of available dot coms that are even remotely pronounceable in English is small and declining rapidly. Hell, Elon Musk didn't even get his hands on tesla.com until 2016—well after he established an empire using teslamotors.com. Nissan, as of publishing, still doesn't own nissan.com. Dropbox started out at getdropbox.com, Caviar uses trycaviar.com. All of these solutions clearly work and cost less than twenty bucks. According to research by WhoAPI, zero four-letter URLs are available to be registered, so I hope you didn't have your heart set on qbmz.com. On the other hand, the general population

is becoming more and more web-savvy. At some point in the not-too-distant future, dot coms are going to be an anachronism. Don't let this be the thing that gets between you and coming up with the right name for your brand.

“At the heart of anything good there should be a kernel of something undefinable, and if you can define it, or claim to be able to define it, then, in a sense, you’ve missed the point.”

–John Peel

Take a look at a few interesting names and see how many of the obvious boxes they tick. We aren't going to look at their URLs because who knows if these were available when they registered.

|                      | Short                               | Easy to spell                       | Easy to pronounce                   | Clear connection to the business    |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| FCUK                 | <input type="radio"/>               | <input type="radio"/>               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Schoolhouse Electric | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input type="radio"/>               | <input type="radio"/>               | <input type="radio"/>               |
| AiAiAi               | <input type="radio"/>               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Antique Olive        | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input type="radio"/>               | <input type="radio"/>               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Mellow Johnny's      | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input type="radio"/>               | <input type="radio"/>               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Piggly Wiggly        | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input type="radio"/>               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Sawzall              | <input type="radio"/>               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input type="radio"/>               | <input type="radio"/>               |
| Arc'teryx            | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Patagonia            | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | <input type="radio"/>               | <input type="radio"/>               | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |

So stop trying to thread the needle with a bunch of arbitrary criteria. Take a little pressure off yourself and your name.

Naming in the right frame of mind

First things first, you're going to need to get comfortable. Being creative comes easy to some people and is a lot harder for others. Creativity is not innate. It's a skill that takes practice to develop. So for starters, get out of your normal work environment. Get away from the distractions, the emails, the TPS reports. Find somewhere (with internet access) that feels like a comfortable thinking space without any distractions. Now have a beer or three and it's time to get naming.









First job of naming:  
getting people to give a shit

One of the biggest mistakes people make in branding is drastically overestimating the degree to which other people care about what you're doing. This leads brands to want to explain their whole offering before even checking to see if the audience is interested. It's like going on a first date and telling your whole life story—probably not going to work out so well. Generating interest isn't typically about throwing a ton of information out there.

“In baiting a mousetrap with cheese, always leave room for the mouse.”

—Saki

You need to show people how you'll make their lives better. You need to get them to a place where they're interested in learning more on their own. Arouse their curiosity. To get there, you're going to need a name that draws them in.



What draws people in?

- mystery
- obscurity
- romance
- subtlety
- comedy
- confidence

Don't think about these words specifically, but think about how you can use other words, in combination with what you're doing, to create these feelings for people.

Examples:

- **Cruel World**  
a job hunting site
- **Inkling**  
a mobile learning platform
- **Ashley Madison**  
hookup site for cheaters
- **Mechanical Turk**  
on-demand, scalable workforce
- **Teenage Engineering**  
electronic music controllers
- **Standard Deviant**  
beer from San Francisco
- **Band of Outsiders**  
fashion label

See how none of these names are trying to explain anything? Even better, they aren't trying to sell you at all. Instead of being a sales pitch, these names work to establish a feeling. They're interesting and memorable on their own.

## Exercise

Try developing a few names for your brand you'll never forget. Test your skills by trying to remember them the next morning. Set a reminder so you actually do it. Why do you think you remembered the names you did?

This image shows a full page of dot grid paper. The background is white, and it is covered with a regular pattern of small, dark grey dots. The dots are arranged in straight horizontal and vertical rows, creating a grid-like appearance. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the page.



Why "trust me"  
says "don't trust me."

Running a naming company, you come across a lot of brand attributes. Hell, we even create our fair share of them. It seems like everyone wants their brand to be trustworthy, approachable, fun, engaging, and innovative. Aside from being borderline-meaningless clichés, it would be great to have a brand that was actually all of these things. The problem is, trust and innovation need to be earned. Saying you're innovative, or that you value innovation, buys you nothing. The only way to be perceived as being innovative is to actually do innovative things. The only way to be trustworthy is to build a rapport with someone, earn their trust, and respect it once you have it.

Interestingly, there's actually an inverse effect at play here. When someone says they're trustworthy, your inclination is not to trust them. Using the word "trustworthy" feels untrustworthy. Another example comes to mind. There's a hole in the wall pizzeria on Gough Street in San Francisco with a sign that says "World famous pizza!" It's obvious there is nothing world-famous about their pizza. If there was a world-famous pizzeria nearby, you'd know about it—there'd be a line out the door. Saying you're world-famous does little more than show that you're not.

So when we have a company come to us and say it's paramount that their name conveys trust, we need to find another way in. While trust needs to be built and earned, what makes someone seem trustworthy? A lot of things from posture to eye contact play into it. Confidence and honesty make us inclined to trust someone. The confident person doesn't say "trust me—" they make you feel safe. Airlines are a good industry to look at as an example. The most important thing for airlines is safety. When you get on a plane, you're trusting that airline with your life while you hurdle across the sky in a pressurized metal tube at five hundred miles per hour. How many big airlines have "trust" or "safety" in their name? None. This is because they know

that using these words actually has the opposite effect. Virgin Atlantic is a great example. Their name, taken at face value, says that they're new to flying. If you were literal-minded in trying to convey safety and security, this name would look like a terrifying proposition. What the name Virgin does have is tons of confidence. And confidence is exactly what you're looking for in an airline you're trusting with your life.

In 2015 we did a renaming project with a small team called Krimmeni who were building a better way to secure the Internet of Things (IoT). Naturally they wanted their brand to convey a sense of security. While we agreed that security was important to the brand, we helped them see that it wasn't a good use for the name. Instead we wanted to use the name as a way for them to talk to potential customers about how they see the world. We settled on the name Rubicon. In January of 49 B.C.E., Caesar and his 13th legion crossed the shallow Rubicon river, disobeying direct orders from the Roman Senate. This led to the Roman Civil War and the Imperial Era of Rome. The phrase "crossing the Rubicon" came to mean passing the point of no return. To the Rubicon team, this represented the state of IoT. Devices were being built and deployed at an alarming rate even though

they weren't being properly secured. The Rubicon had been crossed. There's no turning back now. The name leads directly into the pitch.

“Rubicon is a powerful name because it sets us up to tell a compelling story.”

—Rob Schultz, Chief Product Officer, Rubicon

So remember, if you're trying to use brand attributes as a foundation for coming up with names, it's important to ask yourself how you convey the feeling of your brand attributes. It's almost never a good idea to actually use the words or their synonyms in naming.

## Exercise

Let's turn our focus to innovation. Here are the top five search results on LinkedIn for companies that have "Innovation" in their name. Try renaming them something less obvious.

Innovation Enterprise  
(events services)

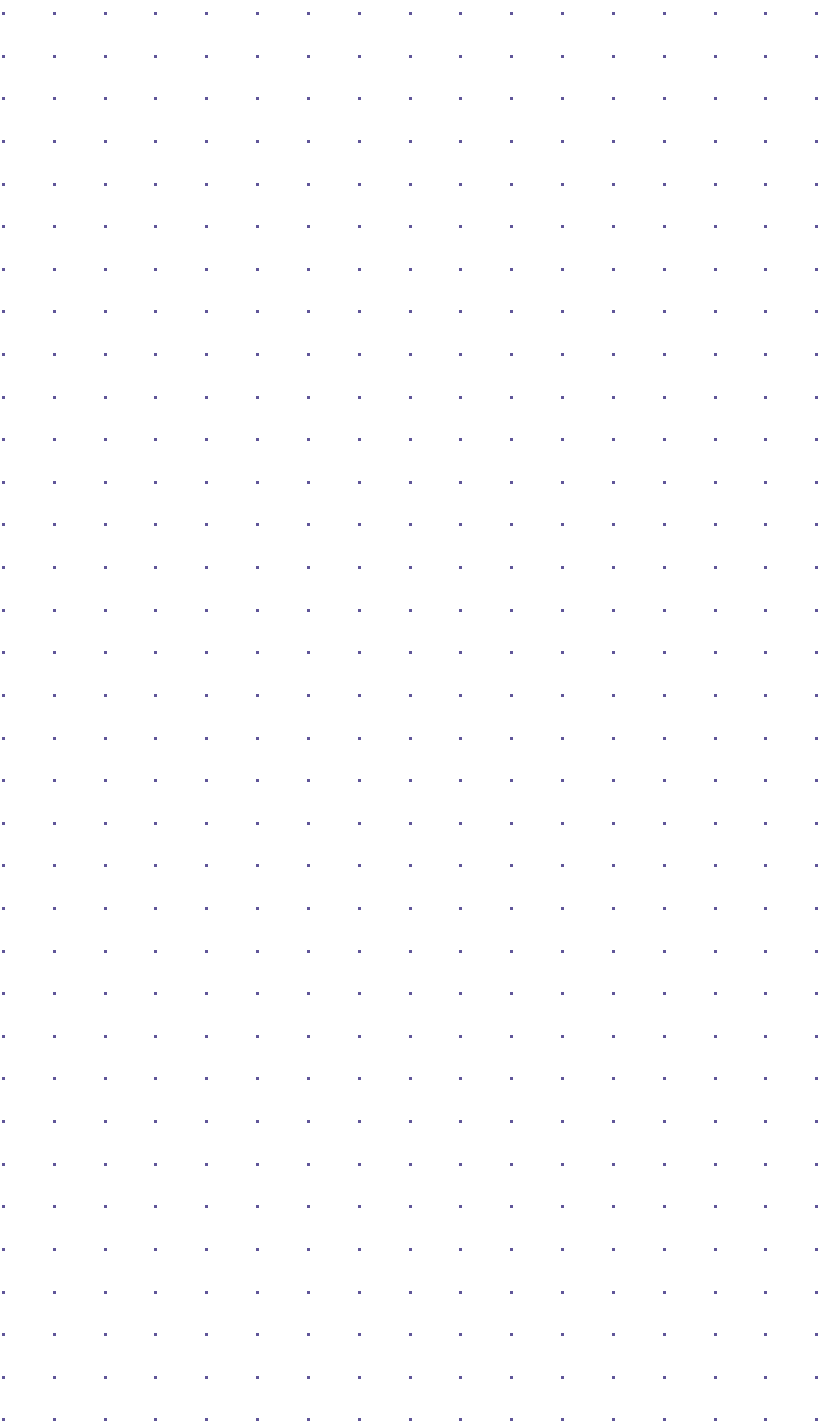
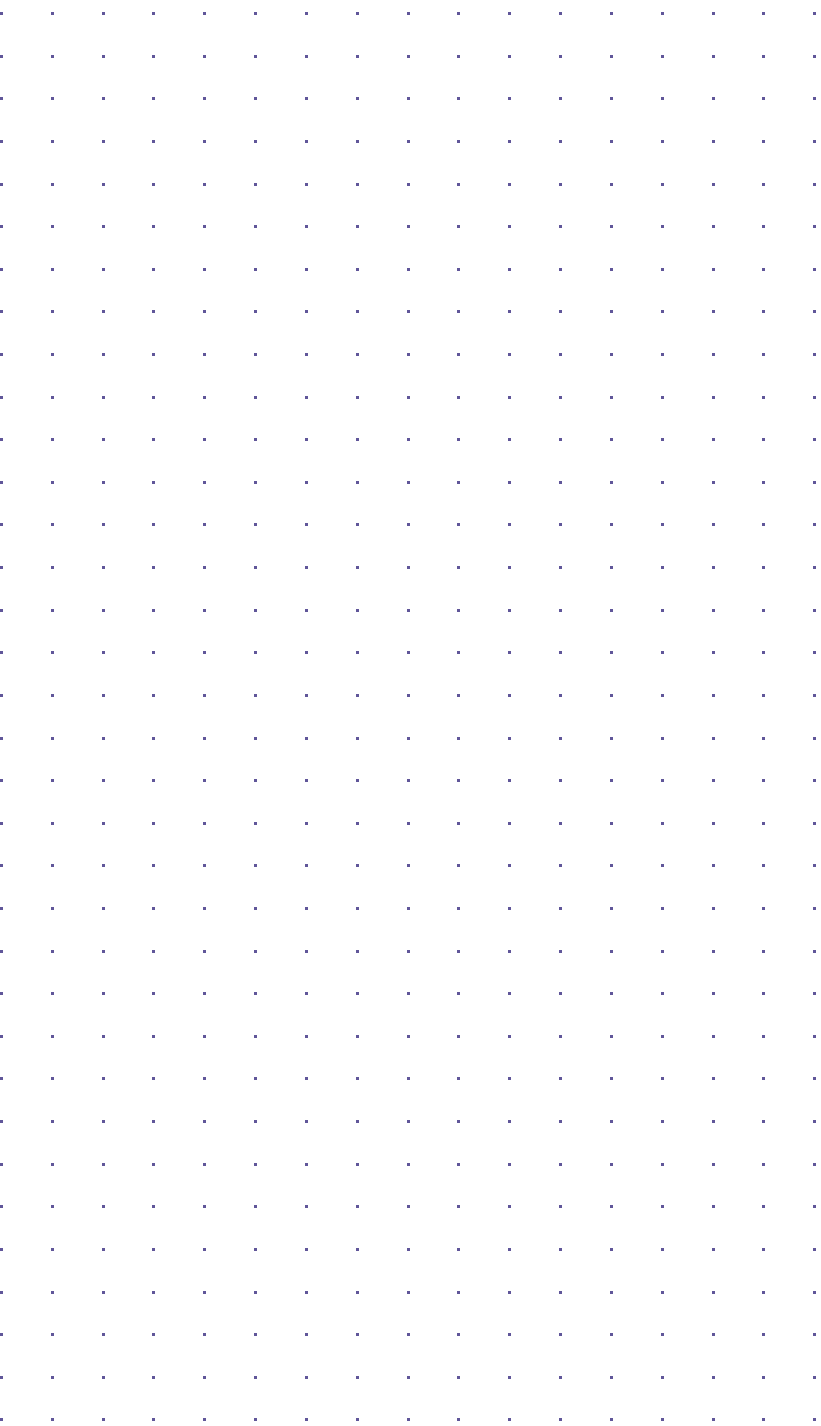
NTT Innovation Institute  
(information technology)

Board of Innovation  
(management consulting)

FinTech Innovation Lab  
(venture capital)

Callaghan Innovation  
(research)

[illegible]





### Lexical synergy or a head-on collision?

There's a big naming misconception in corporate America. It would appear that a lot of companies have gotten the idea that if you smash two words together, people are somehow going to place you at the mental intersection of the two definitions. Comcast broadcasts communications. Instagram lets you make records instantly. Verizon is apparently what happens when you see truth (veritas) on the horizon.

Some people call this a portmanteau. At A Hundred Monkeys we call it a Wordsmash. While these brands have massive advertising budgets to drive recognition of their lexical collisions, they in no way place themselves at the nexus of these concepts. No matter how much you believe in subliminal messaging, when you hear "Verizon" you are not going to think "Oh, veritas horizon!" Even if you did... what would it buy them? Is that what you're looking for in a mobile carrier?

There's a company operating in and around the Bay Area called Extranomical Adventures. The first time I saw the name I couldn't believe my eyes. Extranomical! Is that Extra+Economical, as in these adventures are super cheap? Is it Extraordinary+Economical, as in these adventures are outside the ordinary and cheap? I'm assuming they were going for the latter. Either way, is this what you want in big letters on the side of the minibus when you're on your way to your team building retreat? Doubt it.

If you're just starting out and don't have the money to jam a new word into people's heads, picking a name that grabs attention and connects to what you're doing in an interesting way is a much better approach.

### Wordsmash accident report

Veritas + Horizon = Verizon  
 Product + Perfect = ProdPerfect  
 Communication + Broadcast = Comcast  
 Therapy + Diagnosis = Theranos  
 Climate + Cell = ClimaCell  
 Accent + Future = Accenture  
 We + Inspire = WeSpire  
 Integrated + Electronics = Intel  
 Revenue + Incentivize = Revetize  
 Medical + Electronics = Medtronic

### → Heads up

It's important to remember that just because some of these companies are big doesn't mean that they have good names. In most cases they survived bad names. So yes, it's possible to have a bad name and a successful company. One glance at the Fortune 500 will tell you that. The list of companies that didn't survive bad names would be much longer. So why choose a name you need to overcome when you can have one that grabs attention and differentiates you from the competition?

Back in 2010 we worked with the two-person leadership team at a small cloud-based identity management company called SaaSure. To give them full credit,



the founders knew the name had to change. They wanted to signal that they were in the rapidly expanding cloud space without sounding like everyone else. Because “cloud” was a big buzzword, and a metaphor to begin with, there were hordes of brands using “cloud” and types of clouds like cumulus and stratus in their names. The name we settled on was Okta which is a way pilots measure cloud cover—in eighths. One Okta is equivalent to one-eighth of the sky being clouded. The name was bold and differentiated with a cloud reference for anyone who was willing to dig into its meaning. It’s always nice for a name to reward curiosity when people do a little research.

“It’s tough to separate yourself from the competition. And it’s even tougher when you’re in cloud computing.”

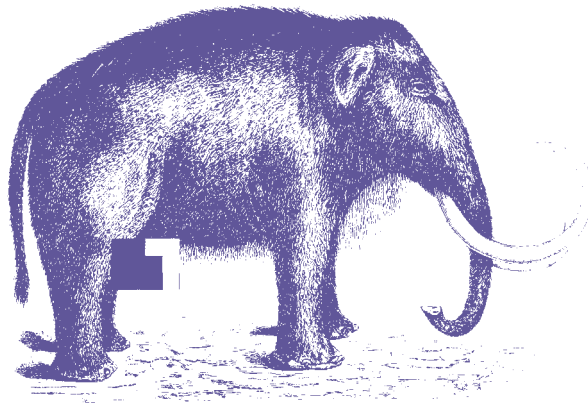
—Freddy Kerrest, President, Okta

—————→ Exercise

Instead of smashing words together, think of a few beliefs or feelings that are core to what you’re working on. Next, try to find words that evoke these feelings or concepts without being too literal or direct.

| Belief/feeling: |           | Belief/feeling: |           |
|-----------------|-----------|-----------------|-----------|
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 1               | . . . . . | 1               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 2               | . . . . . | 2               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 3               | . . . . . | 3               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 4               | . . . . . | 4               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 5               | . . . . . | 5               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |

| Belief/feeling: |           | Belief/feeling: |           |
|-----------------|-----------|-----------------|-----------|
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 1               | . . . . . | 1               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 2               | . . . . . | 2               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 3               | . . . . . | 3               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 4               | . . . . . | 4               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |
| 5               | . . . . . | 5               | . . . . . |
|                 | . . . . . |                 | . . . . . |



Coming up with a brand name isn't like naming anything else. There is an entirely different set of parameters. This is interesting because a lot of people name companies like they're naming their kids. This happens in a couple of ways. First, when you're naming a kid you're essentially just picking your favorite name. There's technically an audience (all the people little Hortense is going to meet in her lifetime,) but the primary consideration for most parents is: "Which name do we like best?" The one way this is similar to brand naming is that there are often people you need to come to agreement with. With kids or pets this agreement is built around something that appeals to the parents. When it comes to brands, it isn't about you as much—it's about the audience.

Another way that people think about brand naming like person naming is when they try to blend in with their peer group. Having a name like Data Aggregation Solutions or Thrivent is like naming your kid John or Sarah. Perfectly acceptable, practically anonymous. In this game you don't want to be the kid who blends into the wallpaper. You want to be the one they can't forget. And it's difficult to accomplish that with a name that says you're afraid to stand out. So who cares if someone makes fun of your name every

once in awhile? If you have confidence in what you're building it's a non-issue.

There's risk built into standing out.

I think we all intuitively know this. Any time you tell a joke or a funny story, there's a chance people won't laugh—and that's embarrassing. What people don't talk about, though, is the risk you take when you don't stand out. Naming, branding, positioning, and marketing are all about engagement—getting people's attention to the point where they actually send something back your way. There is absolutely nothing engaging about a name that makes you sound like everyone else. So you tell yourself you're going to stand out in some other way. Are you?

And even if you are attempting to stand out another way, if your audience balks at your name, there's a pretty big chance you're not going to get that opportunity. So when you actually think about it, not having an engaging name represents a pretty big risk.

Writer John Grossman interviewed me for an article in the New York Times which was cautiously called "Risqué names reap rewards for some companies." He spoke to founders of companies including Holy Crap cereal, Big Ass Fans, and Mammoth

Erection. These founders have a few things in common. Their names help them stand out and attract big business, and they were all happy to find out that most people saw the humor in what they were doing and didn't take offense. Toronto-based Mammoth Erection even does a bunch of work for religious organizations who can see the humor in it. So stop taking yourself so seriously.

## Exercise

Describe who you would like your name to appeal to. Dig deeper than age and gender. Give your audience some character. Model it after people you know if that helps.

Name: . . . . .

Lives in: . . . . .

Shops at: . . . . .

Wears: . . . . .

Afraid of: . . . . .

Loves eating at: . . . . .

Laughs at: . . . . .

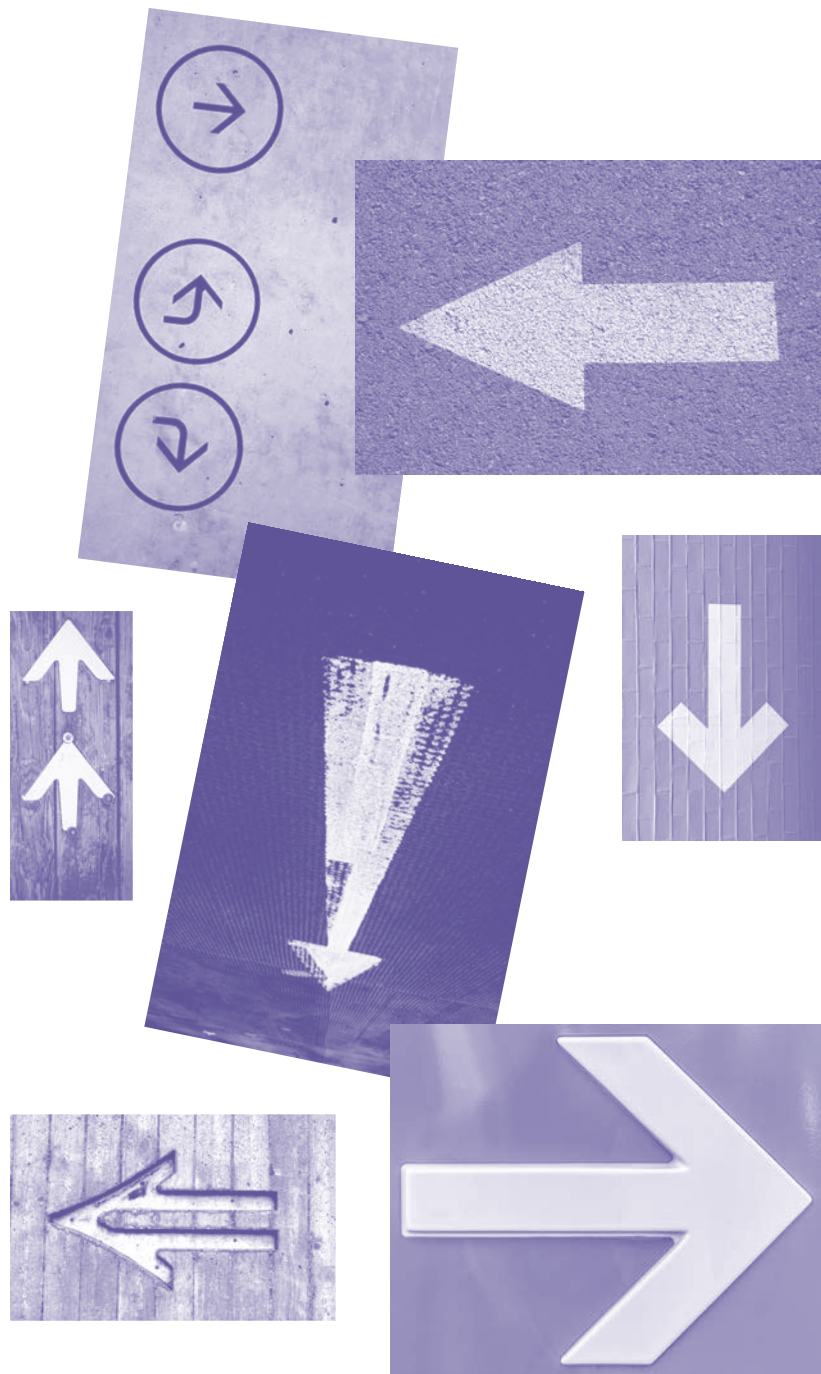
Can't stand: . . . . .

Vacations in: . . . . .

How do they meet their needs without your company/product in their life?

What else helps make them real for you?

Now, when you're developing and evaluating names you have a model for processing how your audience is going to take them in. This allows you to get out of your head a bit and focus instead on who your brand is trying to communicate with. We all have our own idiosyncrasies and irrational sensitivities. Personas can be helpful in seeing beyond them when they get in the way of creativity. If you were to sample how a thousand people in your target demographic felt about your name there would be a fair bit of noise in the form of these sensitivities and other personal reactions that don't hold true for the audience in general. When you only speak to a few people these personal feelings get blown out of proportion. Building a persona helps you see what your audience has in common without focusing on the little things any given person might object to.



## Don't do naming for idiots

Brands these days don't seem to think much of their customers. This is readily apparent when you look at naming. People are afraid to use names that are hard to spell or aren't immediately understandable to someone with a third-grade education. They think that if people can't spell it, there's no way they're going to want to associate with it. This is a bad mistake for a few reasons:

### 1. Everyone does it:

With everyone playing to the lowest common denominator, a very easy way to separate yourself is to establish a brand that isn't so remedial.

### 2. People spend more time on something they don't understand right away:

Since we run into a few hundred names a day (at least), we need a reason to pay attention. Not understanding something right away is a great reason for someone to pay attention. Hell, they might even look it up. Andrew Stanton, co-writer of Finding Nemo and Wall-E, sees this as an essential element of storytelling: "...the audience actually wants to work for their meal. That's your job as a storyteller, to hide the fact that you're making them work for their meal. We're born problem solvers. We're compelled to deduce and to deduct, because that's what we do in real life. It's this well-organized absence of

information that draws us in.”

### → **3. Everything isn't for everyone:**

One of the biggest reasons people try to appeal to the lowest common denominator is that they want their brand to appeal to everyone. Hate to break it to you (them), but nothing is for everyone. Sex and chocolate aren't even for everyone. In fact, you run a bigger risk turning off the one or two audiences who are really important to you by trying to appeal to anyone with a pulse. People are attracted to brands that speak to them. It's hard to have a real conversation with someone when you're worried about what everyone else is going to think. Focus on your customer. If you're successful at communicating with them, they'll pitch other people for you.

### → **4. People like to play up a level:**

Remember when you were in middle school and you thought high schoolers were so cool and grown up? They can drive! Remember when you were in high school and you thought you really belonged in college? We want what we don't have. This applies to love, money, and even knowledge. So just because people might not understand your name right away doesn't mean they aren't going to be attracted to it. Sometimes aiming over people's heads is a great way to get

their attention. What percentage of people who walk into a Starbucks know where the name comes from?

### → **5. If the people you're trying to communicate with are college educated, don't pretend they aren't:**

People like it when you appeal to their intelligence. They like to associate with “smart” brands. And if they don't understand your name or how to spell it, that's what Google is for. Speaking of which, Google comes from Googol which is  $1 \times 10^{100}$ . Do non-mathletes use Google without tripping over its mathematical roots? Exactly.

Figure out who your most important audience is. Find out how to grab their attention. Don't worry about appeasing them yet—that's not a job for a name. Just try to get a reaction: a smile, a question, a genuine laugh, even an inquisitive glance. Here's an exercise to help you get there.

## Exercise

Use Wikipedia to look up a few terms or concepts related to what you're doing. Scan the articles for interesting vocabulary and write it down. Click on internal links that interest you. Dive into a Wiki-hole and regain consciousness on a page about Southeast Asian resist-dyeing techniques. "Batik" has to be a cool name for something.

[illegible]



In 2018 we worked with a company codenamed Feynman Labs. Akin to a library's reference desk, their online platform aimed to provide deep dives into everyday knowledge like how to set up an IRA or shingle a roof—all the stuff your parents forgot to mention and the education system failed to teach. We wanted to tell as much of their story in the name as we could. But what type of name—what symbolism—could get across this idea of iterative everyday knowledge? After a couple rounds of naming we arrived at Holloway. A sunken road worn by age and travel, Holloway was a great avenue to tell about the process of acquiring knowledge. The metaphor suggested that others have walked down this well-trodden path and have first-hand experience. Now, this is a word that most English speakers don't know and that's great. People who want to learn and expand their skill sets are generally open to learning a new word. This is also an example of a word where the definition is hiding in plain sight—a hollow way. This helps to reinforce the story.

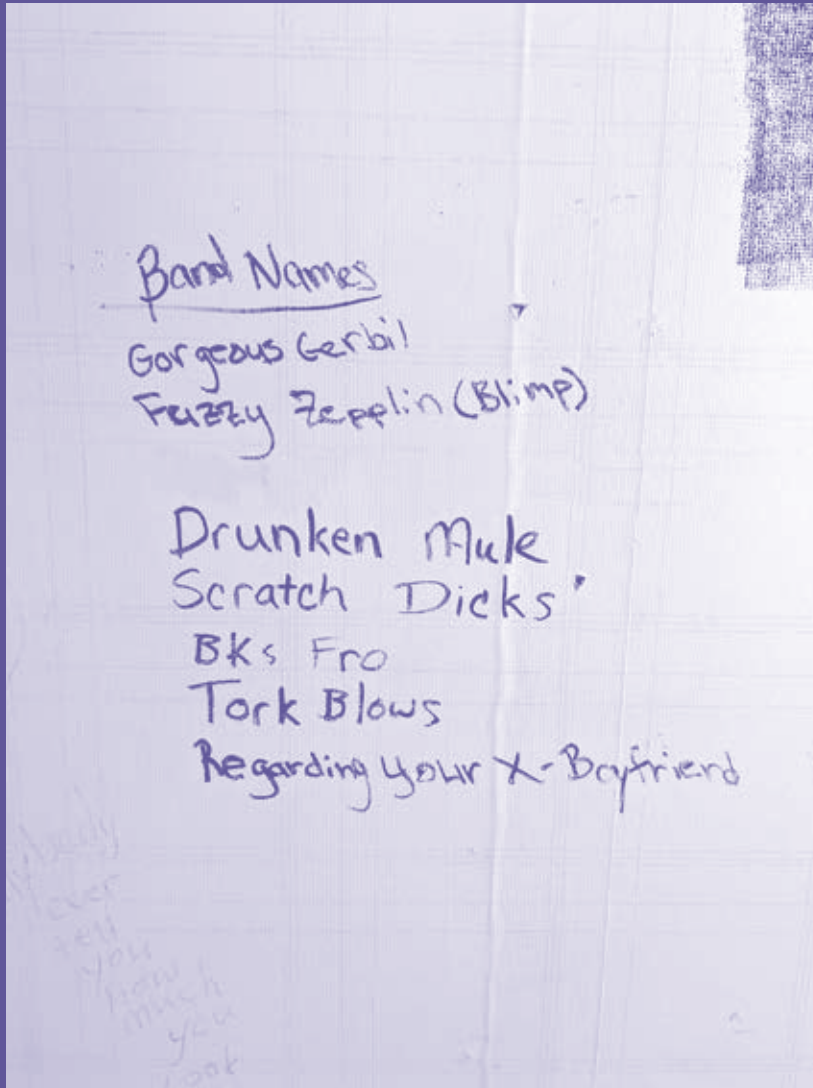
“We believe people shouldn't have to climb the same mountains as those who came before them—their knowledge should be their foundation. Because hollow ways have been walked upon for hundreds of years, we thought Holloway was a perfect fit.”

—Andy Sparks, CEO,  
Holloway

Where do good names come from?

Some names are created and others are found. Spotify, Exxon, and WhatsApp were created. Apple, Virgin, Nike, and Starbucks were found—that is to say, these words existed before big brands started using them. Of course, there's plenty of gray area, too. Names like Snapchat and Evernote simply combine two words that we all know. Names like Flickr, Tumblr, and Waze are derivatives and misspellings of common words.

When it comes to developing names on your own, you should almost always be in the mode of finding words. Maybe issues like URL scarcity and trademark availability force you to drop vowels or smash words together in a pinch, but this should never be your approach to coming up with names. There are so many great words that aren't commonly used—words you can own and define for your audience. Made-up words usually take a lot of work for people to remember and don't have any cool associations built in. Sure, they're ownable, but it's a bit like buying a tiny plot of land in the middle of the desert and trying to turn it into a tourist attraction. So for now, it's best to think of yourself as an explorer on the lookout for cool words and phrases that you can relate to your brand in an interesting way.



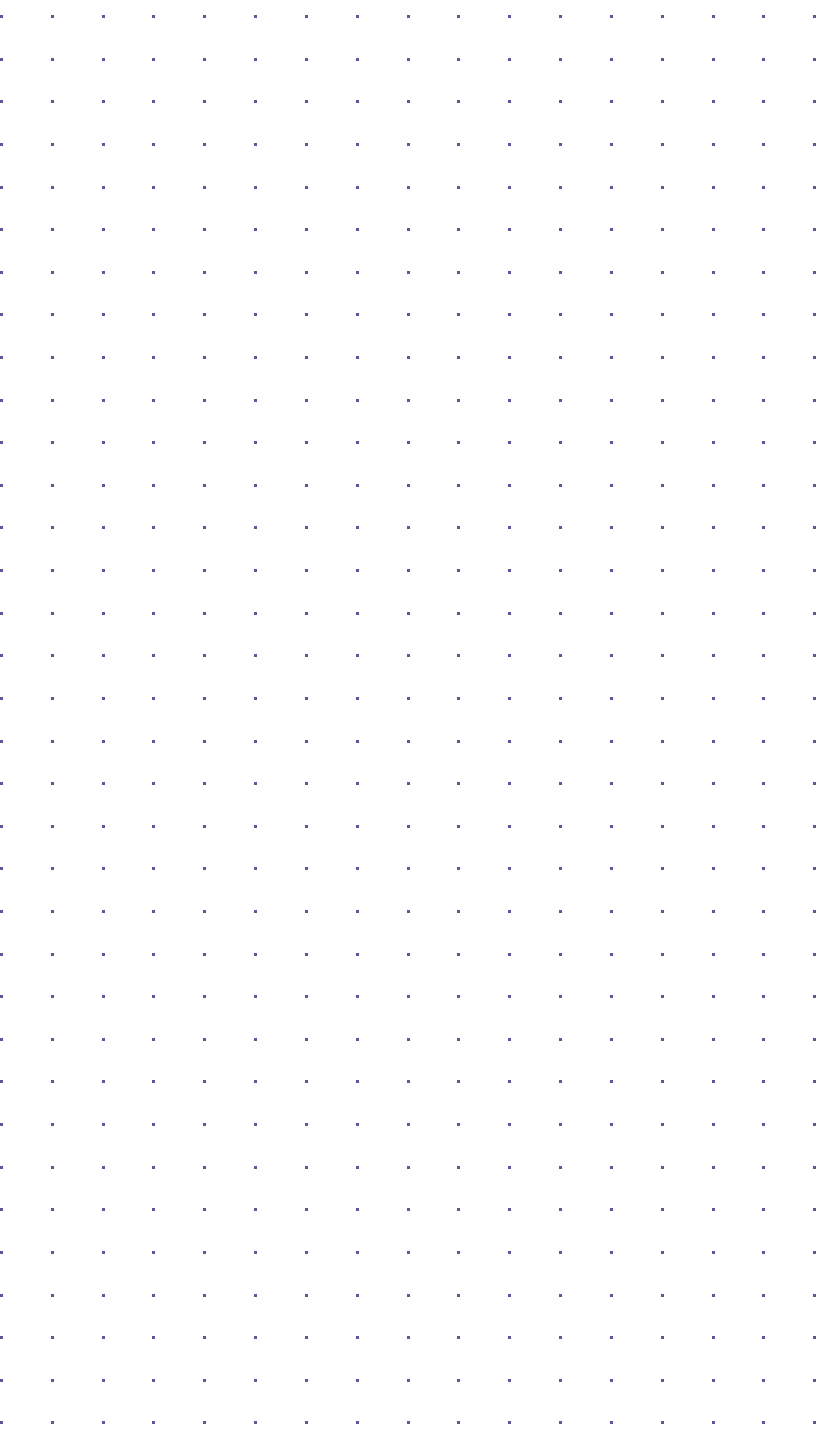
One thing I hear a lot is that all the good names are taken. Lies. This couldn't be further from the truth. All the obvious names are taken, but countless good names are still out there, waiting to be found. The reasons some people think all the good names are taken can be found in the *Jumping Through Hoops* chapter. If you're under the illusion that you need a short, punchy name with a freely available URL, then yes, all the "good" names are taken. However, it's important to recognize that naming doesn't work like economic scarcity. If everyone wants a certain type of name and supply runs low, you shouldn't pay an arm and a leg to get one of the last available options. No. You should run in the opposite direction because clearly there's an opportunity to differentiate yourself on the cheap and allocate your resources elsewhere. As Rory Sutherland, Vice Chairman of Ogilvy, points out in his book *Alchemy*, "'Dog Bites Man' is not news, but 'Man Bites Dog' is. Meaning is disproportionately conveyed by things that are unexpected or illogical, while narrowly logical things convey no information at all."

## Exercise

Find a few obscure references with interesting connections to what you're working on. If you're doing content streaming you could track down a list of old theaters in your area. If you're doing landscaping you could explore different geologic features or page through John McPhee's *Annals of a Former World*.

While some of these words are easy to find, others are hidden in dictionaries of regional English and old magazines. Easy-to-find names are usually hard to acquire and own because they're so frequently used. This is why it's a good idea to look off the beaten path.

[illegible]



When we worked with RealtimeBoard they were growing quickly and looking to move beyond their descriptive name. With a global audience and offices in the U.S., the Netherlands, and Russia, the name needed to work internationally. The easiest solution here would be to invent a name—if it isn't clearly associated with a given language, it wouldn't feel 'from' anywhere. But the RealtimeBoard team had a story to tell. They wanted to share the power of visual communication, especially for decentralized teams. A name that means nothing wouldn't help to tell that story. Through exploring many different avenues into the idea of visual collaboration, we arrived at the name Miro. I'll let Barbra Gago, Miro's CMO, explain what the name means to the team.

“Miró’s work is known for being colorful and abstract. We saw an opportunity to build a brand that is full of colorful visuals and lets us explore the subjectivity of communication, and collaboration. Aside from the direct inspiration of the artist, the word “Miro” has other interesting associations: the connotations of “mirror”, “look”, and “watch” can speak to the reflection, consideration, and visual aspect of what we do to help teams bring their ideas to life.”

–Barbra Gago, CMO, Miro

See all of these built-in meanings and associations? That wouldn’t be possible with a made-up name. They were actually able to acquire miro.com without too much trouble, even though we had agreed that the URL wasn’t a must-have.

—————> Heads Up

Two particularly fruitful areas to find names:

Proper nouns (people, places, things) from stories, myths, music, history:

- Atticus
- Xanadu
- Tecumseh
- Crystal Ship
- Clangor

Obscure words from trades, science, culture:

- Syzygy
- Wingbox
- Status Symbol
- Warbler
- Cresset



### Most short names aren't worth the trouble

At A Hundred Monkeys one of the most common requirements we hear for new brand names is that they must be short. We always ask why, and in the last decade or so I can safely say I've only heard a good answer once. We were working with two founders who left Instagram to build a cool new camera. When we asked why the name had to be short, we learned that the name was going to be etched into the camera's lens bezel in four-millimeter-high letters. Anything longer than, say, "NIKON" wouldn't fit with the other writing on the bezel. Fair enough. We landed on the name Rylo. Short and sweet.

So what about all the other reasons people are looking for short brand names?

- > Short names are more memorable
- > Short names are easier to pronounce
- > Short names are "punchy"
- > Short names sound "sturdy"
- > To compete in this industry we need a short name
- > Most big companies have shorter names
- > Short names are more widely accepted
- > Short names make you sound well-funded

All these statements fall somewhere on the spectrum between disputable and false.

Looking for a short name is one of the easiest ways to turn naming into a needle-in-a-haystack exercise. When combined with the technical parameters people are looking for in a name, like URL, ownable trademark, searchability, and social media handles, the pool of available options is basically unswimmable. There's nothing inherently wrong with short names but a name is a small package to begin with. You're trying to convey a feeling or idea in four or five letters. That's a tall order even before you factor in practical realities. Sometimes you get lucky with URL and trademark but you can't bank on that. If a short name is truly important to you it needs to be important enough for you to relax the rest of your objectives—particularly URL where everything short and meaningful is either unavailable or expensive. Make no mistake—you're giving up a lot by targeting a short name.

## Exercise

Try coming up with some longer names, including names with multiple words. How can you get words to play off of one another to create something new and interesting?

This image shows a full page of dot grid paper. The dots are arranged in a precise, repeating square pattern across the entire surface. There are no margins, text, or other markings present. The dots are a light gray color on a white background.

## → Heads Up

There are certain circumstances where short names make sense for products and product architectures. Maybe your company name is already a mouthful and you're trying to make the combination of company and product name short enough so people might actually say both. Oftentimes the trademark and URL picture for products is simpler than for companies—most products don't need their own URL and product names might not need to be as legally protectable as a company name would. For example, Audi S4 and Volvo S40 seem to peacefully coexist. Either way, if you're looking for a short name, put some genuine thought into why, and where, you would rank it relative to other naming objectives.

Instead of simply bemoaning short names, I think it's wise to spell out some of the benefits of longer names. First, longer names are more ownable and easier to find. They're also easier to find URLs and trademarks for. More importantly, longer names can be imbued with more character. This is especially true of names with multiple words. Try to convey the nuance of names like Norse Projects, Schoolhouse Electric, Africa Twin, or 23 and Me in one word. You can't. Words can play off each other in so many interesting

ways. The level of nuance, specificity, memorability, and differentiation you can achieve with multiple-word names is hard to beat. Weigh that against an irrational desire to have a short name because it "sounds punchy" or a well-established competitor has one.

In 2018 we worked with a furniture company in the Bay Area that allowed people to customize their furniture without long lead times. The marketplace was crowded. We were looking for a way to be attention grabbing and signal furniture without being descriptive. We landed on Inside Weather.

"In a space filled with monosyllabic brand names, the easiest way to immediately set yourself apart is by going with a longer name. If done right, it can be just as impactful as a single-word name, but it also has the power to relate more than just the brand, but a set of ideas and emotions."

—Ben Parsa, CEO, Inside Weather





While logos only exist visually, names exist both visually and aurally. This is a double-edged sword of opportunities and challenges. Make sure you pay attention to how your name both looks and sounds. This feels like something so simple it isn't even worth mentioning, but people screw it up on the regular so here goes.

Some names sound fine when you hear them but leave you in the lurch when you attempt to spell them.

### Airy

1. (Of a room or building) spacious, well lit, and well ventilated
2. Giving an impression of being unconcerned or not serious

### Aerie

1. A large nest of a bird of prey, especially an eagle, typically built high in a tree or on a cliff

\*definitions from the Oxford English Dictionary

Both of these words have cool definitions that could lend themselves well to naming. The problem is they're homophones—words that sound the

same even though they have different definitions. If you're into eagles and want to name your company Aerie, you need to spell it every time to make sure people aren't searching for "Airy," which is also a word and will have plenty of search results. The issue isn't strictly that a name has a homophone. The issue arises when the homophone(s) makes it hard for people to find you. A simple Google search is a good reality check here.

Context can be very helpful with homophones. "No" and "know" are very common homophones that rarely get confused. This is primarily due to contextual clues. Names with multiple words give additional context here. NoDoz doesn't get misheard as KnowDoz even though it sounds exactly the same. Blue Apron isn't misheard as Blew Apron.

Some homophones are much more popular than their counterparts. For example, it's unlikely that people are going to confuse "session" for "cession" or "use" for "yews." These aren't explicit rules. I implore you to use common sense and listen carefully for situations where people have trouble with your name. Don't invent trouble where there isn't any. We have plenty of clients who worry that names sound too much like other words but the connection is tenuous at best. This

is the type of thing that comes to mind when you're examining a name under a microscope in a way no customer or client ever would. For example, we recently had a client who was concerned that the word "liminal" was too close to "limited." This is hypersensitivity.

The other side of this coin is words that might look distinct but are difficult to say.

**Sidereal** /ˌsɪˈdɪrēəl/  
Of or with respect to the distant stars (i.e. the constellations or fixed stars, not the sun or planets)

**Kittiwake** /ˈkɪdiˌweɪk/  
A small gull that nests in colonies on sea cliffs, having a loud call that resembles its name

\*definitions from the Oxford English Dictionary

These words are off-putting in different ways. Sidereal is composed of two very common words, side and real. This leads most people to believe that sidereal is pronounced as side-real when in fact is pronounced side-ear-ee-uhl. It's a cool word with an interesting definition—you just don't want your name story to

always start with “Well, actually...”

Unless you’re an ornithologist, Kittiwake likely means nothing to you. (If you are an ornithologist, thank you for picking up my book! Sorry, but this is going to be the last bird reference.) Not only is it devoid of meaning for most people, it presents pronunciation challenges. Is it “wake” like the wake of a boat, or is it “waké?” This creates a feeling of trepidation for people running into the word for the first time. If this word happens to be your name, your potential audience will likely do one of the following:

- Instantly disregard the name as nonsense and buy from your competition
- Try to pronounce it a few ways with an inquisitive tone
- Look it up

I leave it to you to decide if these reactions are helpful or harmful for your new brand.

Let me be clear, I’m not saying to avoid words that aren’t common vernacular. There are lots of great names that stray from the beaten path. I am saying that in most cases you should avoid words that are both uncommon and intimidating

to pronounce. Ninety-five percent of people who walk into a Starbucks have no idea what (or who) Starbucks is. For those of you who aren’t devoted Melville fans, Starbuck was the first mate on the whaling ship Pequod in Moby Dick. Whether you know this or not, Starbucks as a name isn’t intimidating. It’s essentially a compound word comprised of two words most English speakers know well. Now what I’m curious about is why there isn’t an apostrophe—his name is Starbuck not Starbucks.

Speaking of coffee, around the corner from our office in Berkeley is a coffee shop called CoRo. On the sign outside, right next to the name it says “Coffee Room.” I believe they say this because they wanted to make it clear that their coffee is roasted in a room, unlike other coffee that’s roasted in a cave that just happens to be connected to the electrical grid. By putting “Coffee Room” next to the name as a literal sign of intent, they’re putting their customers at a crossroads. My initial instinct was to pronounce CoRo with the sounds in “COat” and “ROad.” But now that they’ve given us a clue with “Coffee Room” I want to say “CawRoo” which I would never get from “CoRo.” What a mess.

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→ Heads up

Many names are pronounced differently around the country and globe. Ask a Brit to say “Nike.” There’s nothing wrong with a name simply because it can be pronounced a few ways. Tomato, Tomato.

These aural issues aren’t exclusive to pronunciation either. Some names are just awkward to say. For example, Trader Joe’s (I love you Trader Joe’s) has a granola bar called Raises the Bar. So when you read it on the box it says “Trader Joe’s Raises the Bar.” Clever. But how do you say it? “You should try their Raises the Bar” doesn’t really land right. You end up taking the roundabout and saying “Trader Joe’s has these bars called Raises the Bar so when you read it on the box it says ‘Trader Joe’s Raises the Bar.’” Jokes are never funny when you need to explain them.

Again, I’m just showing you the general rules of the road here so you understand the considerations at play. Rules are meant to be broken. This is especially true once you factor in an international audience. On the subject of roads, Cadillacs sell quite well in China even though the name is difficult to pronounce and means nothing for a Chinese audience. Its foreign-ness is likely part of the appeal. Most americans don’t pronounce Vilebrequin or L’Occitane correctly, but the names feel very French which is part of why they’re appealing to people who had J’adore Paris posters in their dorm rooms.

—————> Exercise

Place the following words into either category A - compelling, or category B - confusing

- Palafox
- Trafalgar
- Vibrissae
- Rezina
- Chicane
- Feroner
- Epigone
- Midriff
- Funambulism
- Atavism
- Capitoline
- Exigency
- Prurient
- Polymath
- Tatterdemalion

Compelling

Confusing

CHILDREN  
MAKE  
DELICIOUS  
SNACKS

Names can assume a different character when you abstract them from the sentences and paragraphs in which we're accustomed to seeing them as words. A lot of popular names like Apple and Gap feel pedestrian when you look at their traditional usage and definitions. When you isolate them they feel more powerful and ubiquitous. It's like taking an unknown actor and giving them a leading role. Elevating them, betting on them, makes others take a longer look and try to see what you're seeing. Naming, by its very nature, is an exercise in isolation. By isolating something unexpected, you can generate a lot of intrigue.

While we're talking about isolating words, the context in which names will be seen is still very important. Apple would never work as a fruit company. From a legal standpoint, it would be unprotectable because you can't prevent people from describing their goods. Finding these simple words in contexts where you wouldn't expect them does two things. It makes people curious because they aren't used to seeing a name in this light. It also happens to be much more protectable from a legal standpoint (more on legal considerations later).

Palace is unexpected for a skate company. For that matter, so is Girl. Mother as a name for an ad agency makes you stop and think. Elevating these words to leading roles in unfamiliar contexts makes for interesting names. They make you work to establish some sort of connection. To that point, the relationship between isolation and context is interesting and complex. Indulge me for a moment while we get into the naming weeds.

Some names stand out primarily because they're isolated. The brand Obey is a good example of this. You can test this by seeing how the name would work in an obvious context. For Obey, this could be a dog training business.

OBEY

Dog Training with Juliana  
Ventura County since 1991

The name definitely still stands out. This tells you that the name gets its power from being isolated, not from a shift in context.

Now let's look at names that stand out because of context. Apple is a good example here. Use the same test we did with Obey.

Apple brand apples.

Does the name stand out? No. It literally describes the offering. So the power and draw of the Apple name come from the context switch. When you bring something organic, colorful, and tasty to the world of technology, the context shift attracts attention. What do computers have to do with apples? Curiosity piqued.

Isolation

Obey  
Simple (shoes)  
Gap

Context

Apple  
Palace(skate)  
Mother (ads)

—————→ Exercise

Take your favorite book or a book related to what you're doing and scan for interesting words. You aren't reading, you're looking to take words and phrases out of context and see if they make an interesting connection to your project. Sometimes photocopying a few pages and highlighting provides a useful abstraction.

Here's an example using Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*:

"I am already far north of London, and as I walk in the streets of Petersburg, I feel a cold northern breeze play upon my cheeks, which braces my nerves and fills me with delight. Do you understand this feeling? This breeze, which has travelled from the regions towards which I am advancing, gives me a foretaste of those icy climes. Inspired by this wind of promise, my daydreams become

more fervent and vivid. I try in vain to be persuaded that the pole is the seat of frost and desolation; it ever presents itself to my imagination as the region of beauty and delight. There, Margaret, the sun is forever visible, its broad disk just skirting the horizon and diffusing a perpetual splendour. There—for with your leave, my sister, I will put some trust in preceding navigators—there snow and frost are banished; and, sailing over a calm sea, we may be wafted to a land surpassing in wonders and in beauty every region hitherto discovered on the habitable globe. Its productions and features may be without example, as the phenomena of the heavenly bodies undoubtedly are in those undiscovered solitudes."



While words have their own qualities and associations, context is the lens through which names are viewed in the real world. The same word can transform dramatically in the contexts of different businesses and industries. Let's look at how a few names (some real, some fictional) are perceived in different situations:

**RITZ**

Ritz Crackers

Ritz-Carlton

Ritz, Roman & Herring, LLC

**ACE**

Ace Hardware

Ace Hotel

Ace Ammunition

**STANDARD**

Standard Accounting

Standard Caviar

Standard Cement

Standard Accounting feels boring. Saying “normal” in accounting is not helpful. It reinforces negative stereotypes of accountants being boring pencil pushers.

Standard Caviar is interesting. There's some contrast between the luxury of caviar and the established level of standard. In this context Standard feels modern, almost brash.

Standard Cement, while not being too vibrant or differentiated, has an industrial feel to it that probably has some appeal for your average construction worker or contractor.

Words that feel expected in one industry can play with the perception, tropes, or ideals of another. How a word like “standard” comes to life in certain situations while being rendered inert in other contexts is part of its intrigue. This also has benefits when dealing with the trademark office. While a name like Mango is totally unprotectable in the realm of food, it wound up being quite ownable in fashion.

## Exercise

For the following names, first write down where they would feel boring or obvious. Then think of a few uses where they would be interesting or unexpected.

Kettle:

## Marzipan:

Fingerprint:

Sawtooth:

## Consortia:

A good example of names in new contexts from A Hundred Monkeys is when we worked with Fitbit to name their Wi-Fi-enabled smart scale, Aria. We wanted a name that was light and airy without hitting any notes that felt like diet or weight loss. Aria, as a word, is common in the world of music but it's new in the health/Quantified Self space. We also liked that the name makes you think of “scale” differently—as a series of fluid notes instead of something you step on in the bathroom.

A blank 10x10 grid of dots for graphing. The grid consists of 10 rows and 10 columns of dots, providing a coordinate plane for plotting the function.



It's time to come up with some more names. This time let's be sure we're getting into new territory. We're going to do this by looking at a taxonomy of sorts.

Before PETA was on the scene, the expression was, "There's more than one way to skin a cat." If you're creating a brand name, there are, in fact, a lot of ways to go.

The general consensus (especially amongst lawyers) seems to be that there are two types of names: descriptive and evocative. It's a bit like saying there are two kinds of food: savory and sweet. (Where do you put kettle corn?) It's somewhat true in a clinically technical capacity, but when you're coming up with names, thinking of the world in terms of these two categories is dry and unhelpful.

Yes, descriptive and evocative are two big phyla, but I'd like to dive in a little and look at all the species. So far at A Hundred Monkeys we have come up with 35 different types of names and we're still looking. This is not an analysis. We're not talking pros and cons. If you're trying to create a brand name, there are, in fact, more options than you think.

A taxonomy of species:

- **01. Poetic**  
Names that paint a picture or roll off the tongue  
Bumble and bumble / AiAiAi / Lululemon
- **02. High class gibberish**  
Where do they come from? An ancient dictionary? Outer space?  
Kodak / Zynga / Xerox
- **03. Derivative**  
Almost something you’ve heard of  
Nespresso / Arc’teryx / Zappos
- **04. Initials**  
The easy way out  
KFC / BMW / ESPN
- **05. Acronyms**  
Initials you say instead of spell  
Asics / SAAB / RAND
- **06. Interesting letters**  
Letters that go above and beyond  
TCHO / RAV-4 / THX
- **07. Descriptive**  
Just get to the point  
Airbus / VitaminWater / Whole Foods

- **08. Part descriptive, part fun**  
You might as well have some fun along the way  
Juicy Couture / Mighty Leaf / Big Gulp
- **09. Part descriptive, part emotional**  
We’ve got soul™  
Sublime Frequencies / SoulCycle / Zenefits
- **10. Americana**  
Names that awaken feelings of patriotism  
Baby Ruth / Dixon Ticonderoga / 76 Gasoline
- **11. Into the wild**  
Nature as powerful inspiration  
Patagonia / Juniper Ridge / Wolf Ranges
- **12. Someone special**  
The man, the myth, the legend  
Tesla Motors / Jack Daniels / Newman’s Own
- **13. Made-up people**  
Pure invention with a dose of reality  
Warby Parker / Dr. Pepper / Captain Morgan
- **14. Remember when**  
Names that feel like they’ve been around for a while  
Banana Republic / Old Milwaukee / Crown Royal

- > **15. Suggests the solution**  
What’s in it for me?  
Kryptonite / SubZero / 5-Hour Energy
- > **16. Back to basics**  
Everything else is so complicated  
Free People / Simple Shoes  
/ Country Time
- > **17. Daring**  
Not for the faint of heart  
Obey / Virgin / Big Ass Fans
- > **18. Adrenaline**  
Get your motor running  
Stingray / Speedo / Full Throttle
- > **19. Foreign-feeling**  
Implied sophistication  
Clinique / Häagen Dazs / Tazo
- > **20. Literary/historical**  
Align yourself with something powerful  
Starbucks / Big Bertha / Rosetta Stone
- > **21. Place names**  
Names that take you somewhere else  
Norse Projects / Lonely Planet  
/ Hidden Valley Ranch

- > **22. One letter off**  
So close, yet so far  
Shyp / Zillow / Lyft
- > **23. Vowel droppers anonymous**  
auto-correct’s worst nightmare  
Flickr / Tumblr / Unbx d
- > **24. Mythical**  
A lot to live up to  
Nike / Pandora / Hermès
- > **25. Exclamation**  
Something to get excited about  
I Can’t Believe It’s Not Butter! / Yelp!  
/ Buzz Off!
- > **26. Name as statement**  
Names on a mission  
Forever 21 / True Religion / LiveStrong
- > **27. Latin class**  
Veni, vidi, vici  
Ex Officio / Novartis / Prorsum
- > **28. Utilitarian**  
Names your grandpa would be proud of  
Madewell / X-ACTO / Specialized
- > **29. Blank & blank**  
These are things you remind me of  
Crate & Barrel / Bourbon & Branch  
/ Salt & Straw

- **30. Rhyme time**  
I see what you did there  
RockShox / Fitbit / Piggly Wiggly
- **31. Wordsmash**  
When two become one  
Synchilla / Minecraft / McFlurry
- **32. Opposites attract**  
The romantic comedy of naming  
Fire & Ice / Wild Common  
/ Definitely Maybe
- **33. That’s not my name**  
Familiar and foreign  
Com Truise / Drakkar Nowhere  
/ Yim Yames
- **34. Unlikely allies**  
Unity where you least expect it  
Joy Division / Union Hotel  
/ Partners & Spade
- **35. Simple enough**  
Familiar word, new context  
Apple / Palace / Red

While there are so many different routes to finding a great name, everyone seems to pick from the same two or three groups. Think about why the names from the expanded list of categories work—and how they help their brands get people’s attention and start to tell a story. Expand your horizons a bit—it’s good for you. Come up with some new names in these new categories. What would be the most risqué name you could pick? What’s the best mythical name you can come up with? This search takes equal servings of creativity and research. Don’t be afraid to look under some rocks. Get lost in Wikipedia looking at extinct sea creatures. Explore some fictional characters from the 1800s. With naming, getting lost is one of the best ways to end up with a name that will get you found. Just be on the lookout for an interesting thread—a cool way to tie potential names to what you’re doing. Trust me, everyone has already found the boring ways.

## Exercise

Pick a few categories of names that you think would be good fits for your brand and develop 5 names for each category.

“I want to feel like a gold miner, and I don’t want the gold given to me.”

— John Baldessari





Names aren't brands, yet.

Remember: any name that's already in use isn't just a name. It's supported by a logo and a website and myriad other things that bring it to life. If everything works according to plan, a name and a brand end up meaning the same thing in people's minds. But that's not the case when you start out. At the beginning, a name is just a word or two on a sheet of paper next to a bunch of other words and maybe a doodle of Bart Simpson.

Seeing the potential isn't always easy. So when you're comparing your names against the competition, remember that you're comparing a nascent name with an existing brand. It's a little like looking at a baby and saying, "There's no way he'll be the next Michael Jordan." Not with that attitude he won't.

Instead, focus on your objective. What is the name supposed to communicate to your audience? How does it help you tell your story? Does this name sound different from your competitors' names? Is this name going to be a good vessel for holding your story and products and experiences? If you can focus on these things, your name will have everything it needs to develop into a thriving brand. Remember, the name is just the beginning of your story—don't put more weight on it than you have to.



Staging names in the environments where your audience would normally encounter your brand can be a helpful way to bring them to life. So if you're building a website, you could try mocking up your homepage. If you're opening a restaurant, you could make a sample menu. Evaluating names in a real-world environment is a lot more realistic than looking at them on a blank page. Doing this highlights the context in which your audience will come into contact with your name. People can pick up all sorts of things through context: it's a restaurant, tablecloths and seating arrangement tell me it's a sit-down place, aroma and decor tell me it's a seafood restaurant. These all become points the name doesn't necessarily need to address. This is a weight off your shoulders that frees you up to convey a feeling or personality or something else that isn't obvious and descriptive.

## Exercise

What contextual clues will surround your name? When new customers come into contact with you, what will be obvious? Now take this pressure off your name.

## Why naming isn't a romantic comedy

Something I hear a lot is that people will know the right name when they hear it. They want to be blown away by a name. They want to fall in love instantly. This couldn't be farther from reality. It's a little like seeing someone in a bar and knowing you're going to marry them before you start talking. It's romantic, and life would be a lot easier if this happened to people, but it's not how the world works. People are attracted to this fantasy because it absolves them of all decision-making responsibility. You don't decide to love at first sight. It's a spell that immediately takes over your decision-making faculties. How convenient. Names, like relationships, can be a perfect fit—they just never start out that way. You have to grow into them. If you're looking for perfection from the start you're going to go home empty-handed.

Even if you do somehow fall in love with a name, what's the likelihood it's available? Let's save the storybook romance for Disney movies and take more of a practical approach with naming.

So what are you looking for in a name initially? How can you sense the potential? I spoke about it with editor and long-time collaborator at A Hundred Monkeys, Rose Linke.



Chat between Rose and Eli

**Eli [1:29 PM]**

You have a note that says “more on how it actually works... careful deliberation.” It’d be great to talk more about this. I like the idea of exploring what you should be looking for initially. What’s the potential you can see on day one?

**Rose [1:36 PM]**

That’s a really good point. It is a blend of both. First impression mixed with long-term potential.

**Eli [1:38 PM]**

Right. And there’s a lot in here already about long term but I think it’s interesting to think about the qualities that are present on first impression.

**Rose [1:41 PM]**

Refreshing, not like anything else. It’s hard to be one of a kind.

**Eli [1:47 PM]**

I find that they’re easy to talk about. They make you want to explain and share.

**Rose [2:00 PM]**

Yeah that’s nice.

**Rose [2:32 PM]**

It’s interesting because I think this also indicates a kind of client/person/mindset that we’re looking for. Because the kind of person who will like our work also believes that the sharing/explanation/story is the whole point.

**Rose [3:49 PM]**

I think it also depends on what kind of name we’re talking about it.

**Eli [10:32 AM]**

In terms of product vs. company names?

**Rose [10:38 AM]**

Yes—but also some people expect the name to do all the work, no storytelling required.

**Eli [10:44 AM]**

Which is a lot to ask of a word or two unless you’re being painstakingly descriptive which carries its own obvious drawbacks. Being descriptive only works if you already have a brand that’s grabbing people’s attention.

We get a lot of clients coming to us at A Hundred Monkeys saying they're looking for a name like Eero or Okta. While we're happy that they like our work, when these names first surfaced for these clients they weren't immediate winners. There were other contenders. It was a careful deliberation between options. Now that these brands are big and established, that careful deliberation is forgotten. You grow into your name. In the beginning you're just sensing potential.

Abe Vizcarra used Don't Call It That to help him name his collaborative design studio in Los Angeles. "I wanted something that was a bit utilitarian. Talent Show is common vernacular so people are familiar with it, but not in this context. I was looking to get a reaction. The name is about showcasing not only our own talent, but the talent of our partners and clients, too. It's always a collaboration." But it wasn't a eureka moment (it rarely is). "When I first came up with the name I was curious and skeptical. Then the doubt started to settle in. Can I get a URL? I started having my doubts. Really though, you can poke holes in anything. But it's like a new pair of jeans. The fit is a little rough at first, but as you wear them, they really start to shape around you and the way you move."

## Exercise

Take a look at the names of these grocery stores. Forget everything you know about these companies as brands. Imagine they're new entrants and all you know is that they sell groceries. What do these names communicate on face value?

[illegible]

Perception is reality

Arriving at a name is really just the beginning. Names are living vessels that collect all of the interactions, experience, and news for your brand. Everything new you do gets tied back to your name. While this makes assessing new names difficult, it's what gives lasting brands their brand equity and reputation. Releasing a product or launching a new advertising campaign affects what your name means to people. Some of these effects are within your control while others are not. In 2014, ISIS Chocolate of Belgium saw a sharp decline in sales. Did it have anything to do with their fine Belgian chocolate? No. Wikipedia cites 11 companies and organizations that have changed their names due to the rise of ISIS in Iraq and Syria. This list also includes the mobile payment venture of AT&T, T-Mobile, and Verizon. Even with their combined marketing clout, they wanted no part of ISIS. What once brought to mind an Egyptian goddess now evokes violent extremism.

When we're doing naming projects we always ask people about names that they really like. While they might not be looking for the same qualities in their new name, it puts down some stylistic markers for us. This question also ends up being a sign of the times. In the early aughts, Yahoo was the most common response we heard.

Everyone loved its irreverence and energy. As of writing, I can't recall the last time I heard someone say they liked Yahoo as a name—has to have been over a decade. What happened? Did the name suddenly become bad? No. Yahoo is still a great name. It's fun and memorable and did everything the company needed it to do in their growth years. Alas, the company made some questionable acquisitions and saw their market share dwindle. So now when people think of Yahoo, it doesn't sound like a name they want to be modeling themselves after. As the company evolved, so did the way people perceived the name.

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—————→ Exercise

Try out some names in a few headlines to see how your actions change how people perceive your name.

————— helps us rethink how to —————

————— brings new life to the —————  
business

————— ignored critical warning signs, report finds

————— Increasing competition pushes —————  
to the brink

————— founder seen on video excoriating local  
restaurant staff

————— 's rise signals a shift in —————

As business slows —————  
searches for answers

So while it's a natural feeling to want to control every aspect of how a name and brand is perceived, it's important

to accept that some of it will always be outside of your control. If a journalist wants to write a negative article about your company, no name is going to save you from the headline. So stop worrying about it. The more popular you become, the more likely it is that parts of your brand will grow beyond your control. Look at how many times Nike and Facebook and Chanel get misappropriated. People print Swooshes on acid tabs. While most of these giants vigorously defend their marks, it just means that they've grown so large within our collective conscience that they've become part of the zeitgeist. It's also worth mentioning that some brand names grow so large that they actually lose the ability to protect their name. For example thermos and escalator became so commonplace that they went from trademarks to common names. Remember to play a tiny violin for the companies and products that get so ubiquitous they lose their trademarks. More on this in *The Proving Grounds*.

Acronyms are particularly prone to picking up new meanings over time. If you're thinking about using an acronym as a name, not only do you need to be concerned about acronyms that already exist, you need to think about the acronyms that could exist. Given how often acronyms are used in medical

and military environments, there's a chance your well-researched acronym could become a new strain of antibiotic-resistant chlamydia or a shiny new missile. Look at the disambiguation pages for acronyms on Wikipedia. You'll be surprised what you'll find. For example, what does RFP mean to you? Given the creative leanings of the kind people who might pick up a naming book, I'm going to guess most of your minds go right to Request for Proposal. As of writing, Wikipedia lists ten uses for the acronym including Russian Fascist Party and Rapid Fire Pistol. Check it out for yourself.

Jacki Lyden once interviewed me for a funny segment on NPR's Weekend Edition about the Wisconsin Tourism Federation changing their name because WTF had taken on more meaning than when they had named themselves originally. My two cents was to lean into the name. They could have had some fun with it and made guides that said "WTF to do in Wisconsin." Anyway, they didn't see the humor in it and decided to rename themselves the Tourism Federation of Wisconsin. Guess which acronym has since become popular? That's right—TFW. You know That Feeling When you're trying to avoid acronyms with other meanings and you just can't escape?



Don't

If you ask people what they think, you're sure to end up with more opinions than you can safely manage. It's best to keep it between yourself and the few people you trusted enough to start this crazy project with in the first place. That means not inviting every developer, former colleague, and old friend to join the conversation—even if they say they “have marketing experience” or “have named a few things before.”

Nothing ruins creativity like too many voices weighing in. We call it the Ice Cream Principle. Tell 10 people to go get ice cream with one condition: they all have to agree on one flavor. That flavor is going to be chocolate or vanilla every time. Groups of people don't agree on what's cool or interesting, they agree on what's easy to agree on. Don't pick a name strictly because it's the top vote-getter.



This applies to focus groups, too. A lot of people try to focus group or “A/B test” names. It’s seen as “safe” because you’re letting consumers make decisions for you. This is not what focus groups are for. They’re for learning about people’s problems and desires—understanding where they’re coming from. Focus groups are not supposed to make decisions for you. So while there are a lot of good reasons to do focus groups, naming is not one of them.

As Dan Pallotta points out in his Harvard Business Review blog post “Real Leaders Don’t Do Focus Groups” [[ahundredmonkeys.com/dcit](http://ahundredmonkeys.com/dcit)], asking someone what they think when it comes to something creative is a pretty clear signal you’re lacking confidence.

This applies to naming. You can’t focus group names because creativity is hard to test and harder to quantify. It would be like using scientific analysis to find great art. It doesn’t work that way. The environment of the focus group is entirely contrived.

In the real world, people are never asked how they feel about names devoid of context. They’re used to seeing names as part of a bigger whole—active brands in the real world. Attempting to isolate the name as a variable is unnatural and

foreign to the people you would be asking. This, however, does not mean these people won’t be happy to give you their opinion, typically delivered in a manner disproportionately forceful relative to how they actually feel about it.

“The trouble with market research is that people don’t think what they feel, they don’t say what they think, and they don’t do what they say.”

–David Ogilvy (ostensibly)

We worked with a team at Sidewalk Labs who were building a technology platform to help cities and governments better understand and regulate their transportation infrastructure. Considering the team believed deeply in the power of data, initially they wanted to look for more data points on potential names by asking people close to the project for their opinions.

“Everyone has an opinion on naming. You start asking people what they think and pretty soon you end up with more opinions than you can safely manage. Once you finally commit to a name people stop seeing it as an option and start seeing it as reality. We were debating other options besides Coord but looking back on it, it’s hard to imagine us going with anything else.”

–Stephen Smyth, CEO,  
Coord

One thing that strong names have in common is the ease with which they can be attacked and dismissed. For example, imagine that you were in the corporate meetings where the following names were put on the table. After each name are possible comments, any of which would have been sufficient to kiss that name goodbye.

### **Apple**

- Full of worms
- Easily bruised
- Fall from grace
- Doesn’t sound like a computer
- What kind of education are we talking about here?

### **Virgin Atlantic**

- Says “We’re new at this”
- Nobody will take us seriously
- Unprofessional
- Religious people will be offended

### **Banana Republic**

- Ugly stereotype
- You’ll be picketed by people from small, hot countries
- Do you import produce?
- Too long

### **Caterpillar**

- This is big equipment, not tiny bugs
- Too cute for construction
- Easily crushed

So given all of this surface negativity, why do these names work? What would you have needed to know in order to have predicted their success, rather than their failure? All names have weaknesses. Just like with people, sometimes weaknesses can be a great source of strength. These brands decided to represent themselves

in a way their competition was afraid to. There's a quiet confidence in that. These "obvious flaws" are a big part of why these names strike us as strong and different. Besides, a name acquires the personality traits you give it over time. Branding and design are used to help people see a name in the light you're intending. It's obvious when you fly Virgin that their name speaks to a new flying experience instead of their first flying experience. So don't be afraid of a little negativity or a dismissive comment. Some of the best names in the world would have been quickly dismissed if their founders focused on the negative.

Remember, interesting names have a back story—they come from somewhere, they arouse curiosity. And no story worth your time is all sunshine, smiles, and rainbows. Every name has weaknesses. Every word that isn't clichéd to death isn't a flawless representation of beauty, strength, and speed. This is what it means to be human—embrace it. Don't fall into the same corporate stupor where you'll find words like synergy, innovation, and solutions. Words that act like not-so-radiant beacons, telling the world you want to be just like everyone else.

“I’m at war with the obvious.”

–William Eggleston

→ Exercise

What are your favorite names so far? Don't tell anyone.

Testing names if you absolutely have to

First off, do you actually have to? Or are you just looking for a way to outsource your decision making and stick blame elsewhere if people don't like the name? We find that the vast majority of times people want to test names they don't actually need to and the testing they're proposing won't actually yield any useful information. But let's just say that your tyrant boss is demanding it or you have a unbendable corporate policy (shudder) that requires it.

If you're ever going to involve other people in the naming decision-making process (which is exactly what you're doing by testing names), you need to do it in a way that simulates the way they would actually come into contact with a name in the real world. "I was thinking about maybe naming my company Orbiter, what do you think?" is not a question people are equipped to answer. The question makes you sound unsure. Other brand names aren't optional with a question mark. They're fixed and not up for debate.

So here's a simple setup for testing naming should you absolutely have to: Let's say you're naming an airline. Take three names you're considering and combine them with three logos you can place on the side of a plane in a staging example. If you have design skills and

FIG. 1 — FOOT

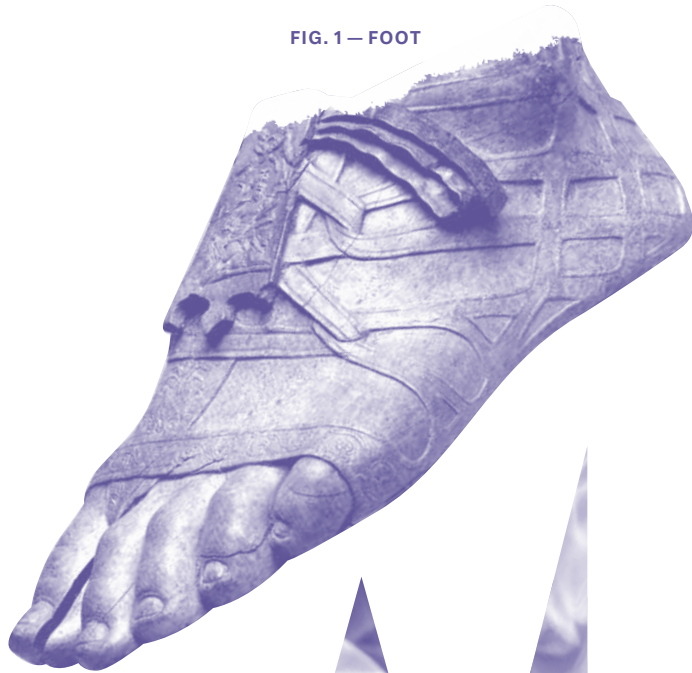


FIG. 2 — FIRE



want to overdo it on the staging, go ahead. This will leave you with nine staging slides, three names with three visual treatments each.

Next you'll segment your testing audience (who, hopefully, is similar to the brand's real audience) into three groups like so:

| Group 1           | Group 2           | Group 3           |
|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|
| Name 1 / Design 1 | Name 1 / Design 2 | Name 1 / Design 3 |
| Name 2 / Design 2 | Name 2 / Design 3 | Name 2 / Design 2 |
| Name 3 / Design 3 | Name 3 / Design 1 | Name 3 / Design 1 |

Then you'll build a simple questionnaire asking your audience something like this:

- > Which plane stands out to you the most?
- > Which is the strongest brand?
- > Which plane would you fly in?

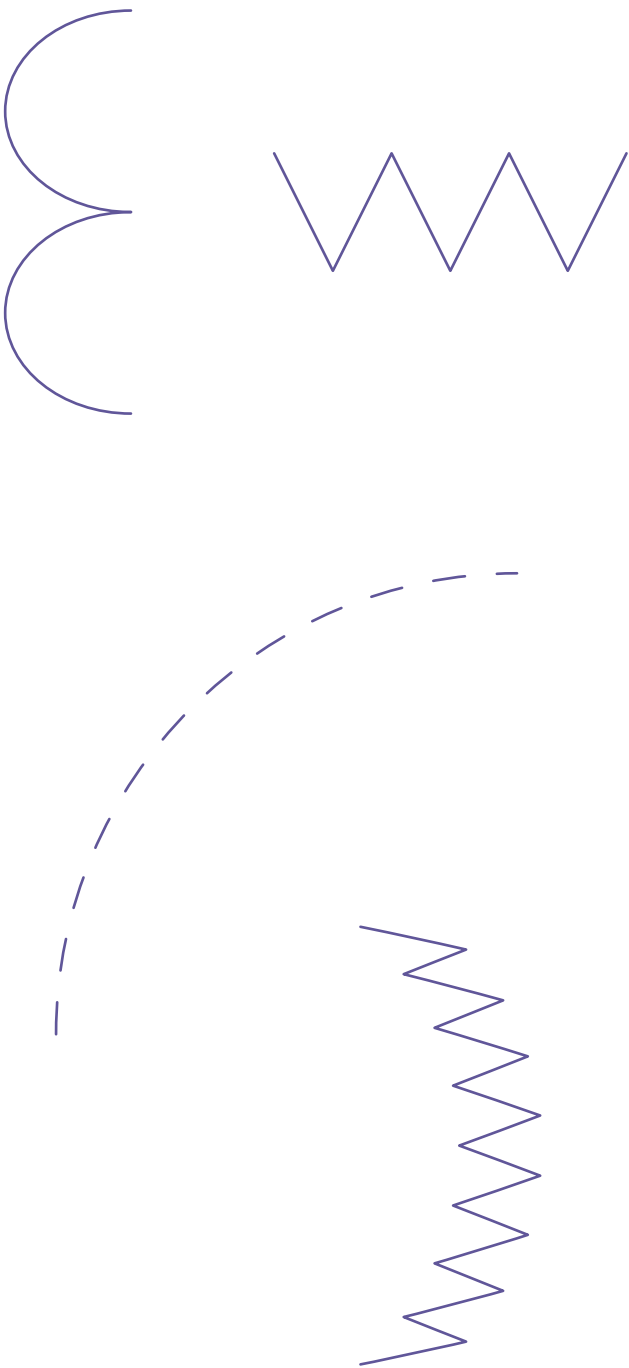
Notice how we're not asking about the name specifically. This is intentional. As we discussed earlier in the chapter, people are never asked about names specifically. It's always about the overall brand. If people don't mention the name specifically, that's fine.

Next you group results by row, looking at the comments and answers on a per-name basis. This way you can strip out the results per-design and see which name resonates the strongest.

Now, this is far from perfect. You could have a small sample size. The design could have an outsized effect on the results. But this is a quick and dirty way to see if there are any big blind spots on the names that you might be missing. Remember, we aren't outsourcing our decision making here. You're still in control. Once you've ruled out any obvious blind spots, name testing has served its purpose and you can move on and make a decision like the adult you probably are.

More than once we've seen clients go through the research process only to disagree with the result. It's a bit like when you try on two outfits and tell a friend you can't decide between them. They say they prefer outfit A which galvanizes your support for option B. If all you get out of testing is a renewed sense of autonomy—great.

Trends have their place,  
and naming isn't it



There are a lot of garden variety names that have been clichéd to death. For a while in the '90s everyone seemed to be into Latin words—so academic and classical. After that came vowel-dropping: Flickr, Tumblr, Dopplr. These names exist primarily because of URL scarcity. Can't get evocative.com? Try vocativ! Engine.com taken? No worries, try Engin! The problem here is that you're looking for a name for your brand, not just a URL. Repeat after me: "My name is bigger than my URL." Say it a few times.

The newest breed of cliché name is the Blank & Blank—names like Salt & Straw, Milo & Olive, Faith & Flatulence. While these names have the potential to be evocative (putting two words together always has the potential to be evocative), the device, [Blank] & [Blank], is trite. Names like these might make getting a URL or trademark a little easier but so does any multi-word name that isn't a common phrase.

Every brand, no matter how web-centric, also exists in real life. We all spend a lot of time telling people what we do. We hand out business cards and talk to potential partners. Your name is just as important here as it is on the web. And when people ask you why you're called Engin, "...because engine-with-an-e

wasn't available" is not a good answer. Neither is, "It's just something we came up with. It works for now." Answers like these do not help you build a brand. Names are supposed to last the life of your business. Trends are supposed to last until next season.

Chat between Eli and Rose:

**Eli:** It's interesting to think about the trends we've seen over the years and the go-to clichés that accompany them.

**Rose:** Let's see...when I first started here 10 years ago, everyone was making an app. Then everything was about the cloud. Then big data. Then literally every project we did was a platform.

**Eli:** Right, that was always the big reveal when we were on-boarding... "what we're actually doing here is building a platform."

**Rose:** These days we have machine learning, direct-to-consumer, blockchain. And every single thing must be seamless!

**Rose:** God(dess) forbid any seams!

**Eli:** The direct-to-consumer play is usually about getting people to go from "I buy it when I need it" to a subscription model where it just shows up whether you need it or not.

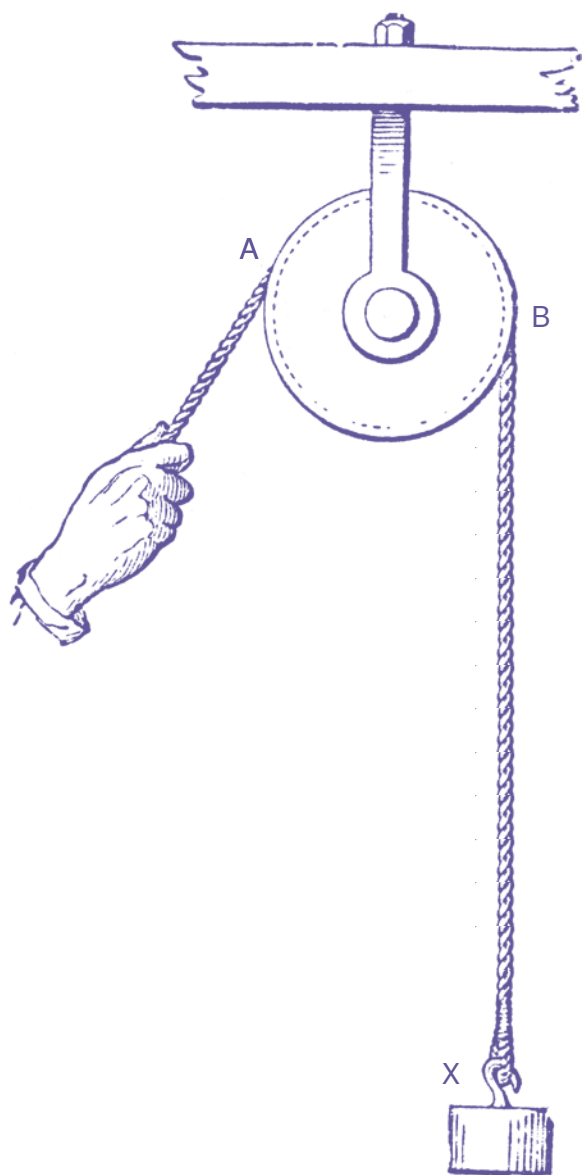
**Rose:** Is this why so many of the DTC brands use a person's name? To try to put a human face to a recurring charge on your credit card?

**Eli:** Hah, like you're paying for childcare or a dog walker... At least it shows some tact relative to all the cloud company names that were "CloudX" or "CirrusY"

**Rose:** Yeah—I think cloud companies really had a tough time with naming. It was hard to get out of the built-in metaphor of the category.



## Can a “Verbable” Name Help You?



One of the most common things clients ask for in a name is the ability to use it as a verb.

“Google it”

“Skype me”

“Photoshop that”

“Let’s Lyft there”

While some names lend themselves to “verbing” better than others, it’s really more a factor of popularity than the ease with which a name can be used as a verb. Looking at the examples above, when people were first introduced to Google and Skype, the names lacked associations. This makes it easy to interpret an unknown word as a noun or a verb. Photoshop is a clunky name. It does contain two words that can both be used as nouns and verbs but “Photoshop it” has a lot more to do with it being an industry standard than any sort of implicit “verbability.” Not every brand needs to be an action—even if there are actions involved. If people are talking about your brand, they’ll find a way.

“Just Twitter it” doesn’t have a ring to it, but “tweet it” does. Without critical mass, getting adoption for an invented verb is a fool’s errand. If your name has poetry or is fun to say, and is relatively short, you’re putting yourself in “verbable” territory. Now you just need a few million fans.

—————> Exercise

Take your verbs for a spin:

\_\_\_\_\_ it.

\_\_\_\_\_ me.

\_\_\_\_\_ that.

Let’s \_\_\_\_\_ there.

I \_\_\_\_\_ therefore I am.

\_\_\_\_\_ it.

\_\_\_\_\_ me.

\_\_\_\_\_ that.

Let’s \_\_\_\_\_ there.

I \_\_\_\_\_ therefore I am.

\_\_\_\_\_ it.

\_\_\_\_\_ me.

\_\_\_\_\_ that.

Let’s \_\_\_\_\_ there.

I \_\_\_\_\_ therefore I am.



What your name says about you.

Let's look at an interaction we've all had a bunch of times:

"Hi, I'm Leslie."

"Hello there."

"What do you do?"

"I'm the CMO for Vasticity, we make cloud apps."

"Oh, cool," says Leslie, maintaining an uncomfortable level of eye contact.

"So what do you do Leslie?"

"I work for Klipspringer."

"What's Klipspringer?"

"It's a relative of the antelope that lives in the African grasslands. It can jump 15 times its height to see predators above the tall grass."

"Ha, cool."

"Yeah, we do DevOps. It's easy to get caught in the weeds. We jump over all that stuff and look at everything from a higher level."

Clearly Leslie knows what she's doing.  
Diving a little deeper:

- 1. "I'm the CMO for Vasticity. We make web apps." There are a few issues here. First, the name: Vasticity sounds totally made up. There are a few pleasing sounds and maybe an oblique reference to being big but absolutely nothing to catch anyone's attention. The name is designed to go unnoticed—a bad idea for almost any new brand. Also, never say you make web apps. Web apps are rapidly approaching ubiquity. When you're introducing someone to what you do, why would you ever want it to sound uninteresting? Be sarcastic if you have to. No one is going to be interested in what you're doing if both your name, and the way you describe what you do, are yawn inducing.
- 2. "I work for Klipspringer." Klipspringer is an interesting word. It's a word that some people have heard of but probably can't place. This is a good thing. It sounds different and fuels curiosity which puts you in a position to show people why you're different. If your name sounds like everyone else's why should people believe you're not like everyone else?

- 3. The payoff. It's always good to reward people's curiosity. When you ask "What's Klipspringer?" there's a payoff—connecting the name to what you're doing in a cool way. Some great names make sense immediately. Those that elicit a question need to have a good answer. Creating the connection between the name and the positioning increases the likelihood people are going to remember your name and what you do. Your name should get a reaction, and a question is a great reaction. A question should lead you right into your pitch—so long as your name has a cool connection to what you're doing. This most likely has nothing to do with misspellings, dropped letters, and antiquated European languages. So pay careful attention to people's reactions when you tell them "I work for Klipspringer." Do they ask a question? Are they curious or interested? Are they just being polite because they're awkward with small talk? If your name transitions well into talking about what you do, it has done its job.

When I tell people I work at A Hundred Monkeys, they're practically forced into a follow up question. The name demands it. The conversation goes something like this:

"What do you do?"

"I run a company called A Hundred

Monkeys.”

“A Hundred Monkeys? What do you do?”

“We help companies find good names.”

“Why are you called A Hundred Monkeys?”

“There’s a saying that if you put A Hundred Monkeys at a hundred typewriters, eventually you’ll come up with a sonnet of Shakespearean quality. For us it’s a comment on process. We need to develop hundreds of names to get to the final answer.”

The name gets the question.

The answer makes the name stick.

In 2018 we partnered with two bankers who left their jobs in the mortgage industry to rework the way people get home loans.

“The working name, Rate Gravity, placed the company in a sea of sameness; pitching rates instead of working to put their customer’s interest, first. The solution works two-fold. ‘Own Up’ brings clarity and honesty to an industry that’s been known to put a bank’s agenda before their customers’. It also empowers people to see the upside of homeownership. The company’s purpose is front and center, the first time you see the name. Ultimately, their name leads to their ‘pitch’—helping them speak about their business in an ownable way.”

–Brentos Fernandez,  
Head of Design at Listen,  
our design partner on the  
project

## Exercise

Take a few of your favorite names and jot down how they start to tell your story.

The great names of the world have one thing in common. They're about more than selling people shit they don't need. They're not just about trying to sway them with marketing rhetoric. They're about speaking human language in an effort to communicate something worth saying. They have nerve, ambition, personality, a mission, and yes, they take risks. Because the easier a name is to spell or pronounce or recognize or understand or label, the easier it is to forget. And there is nothing about a great name that is forgettable. Your name is the opening to the story about who you are and why you matter—bad names get a story off to a bad start. Think of your name as a thesis statement: it's a way to inform and curate the experience you're creating.

“Making the simple complicated is commonplace; making the complicated simple, awesomely simple, that’s creativity.”

–Charles Mingus



### Do your names have the right stuff?

You're probably thinking, "Awesome, we have a list of names, now let's pick our favorite." Wrong. Because of lawyers, you have a little more work to do.

#### → **Preliminary screening**

Look at all the names you've come up with. Highlight both the ones that are your favorites and the ones that do the best job of helping you tell your story.

Google the names along with a few keywords for what your company does. So if you're an app development company search "[name 1] app development" or whatever you think would yield results of relevant competition. If you find someone who does something in the same field as you with the same name, cross the name off the list. If you aren't sure, keep the name for now. Rinse and repeat for all your other highlighted names. You're going to submit the ones that pass inspection to an IP (intellectual property) attorney for scrutiny, but you might as well save yourself a couple hundred bucks eliminating the options you know are taken.

#### → **Legal screening**

For as much as people focus on URL availability, it's a lot more important to make sure you do your homework in the trademark department. A URL can be changed relatively easily. A cease and



desist, potential damages, plus finding and implementing a new name is a serious wrench in the gears no matter how you look at it. Thankfully, this is why IP attorneys exist. You can typically get a preliminary report in the neighborhood of \$50/name. You're going to need to give them a short description of the legal territory you want to cover.

The report you get back should give you an idea of how available your potential names are. When you get down to your final three or four contenders, it's a good idea to run a more exhaustive search that includes things like common law conflicts (where someone is using a name, has some rights, but hasn't registered). This costs a little more money and takes a little more time, but it's a far better option than not knowing what's out there.

Just because you do a Google search and see some people using your name, doesn't necessarily mean you can't use it. As lawyers explain it to me, it's like a party: If you ring the door uninvited to a party and there's just a few people there, it's highly unlikely they're going to let you in. However, if you show up to a party and the door is open, there's obnoxious techno blasting, and a ton of people milling around, you might be able to get away with joining. So if there are just a

few people with a trademark, they're probably going to want to protect it. If it's a crowded party, trademark ownership gets pretty complicated and people are less likely to defend their marks because they'll probably have a harder time proving that you're invading their turf.

Considering I've never been to law school, I figured it would be a good idea to hear about trademarking names from an actual trademark attorney who works on this stuff every day. So I sat down with Rebecca Liebowitz of Venable LLP in Washington D.C.

#### → **Who are you and what do you do?**

I am Rebecca Liebowitz. I am a trademark attorney. I have been in the trademark field for about 20 years—started as a file clerk and a paralegal and I've had just about every title you could have. I have been a lawyer for about 10 years. I focus largely on trademark clearance and prosecution—searching to see if trademarks are available, working on licensing and deals, purchasing trademarks, looking for potential issues and strategizing around them.

#### → **Do I need to trademark my new name?** Yes.



### → **Care to expound on that?**

In the United States, trademark rights are established through filing or through use. If someone starts using a trademark, they don't actually need to register in order to develop rights. However, filing a federal trademark gives you presumptive nationwide rights. In other words, even if you're only using your mark in Southern California now, if you have a federal registration, you should be able to move into Florida easily. Common law rights (established through use) only apply to the geographic area where you're in business. So if you only have common law rights and are using it in Southern California, that doesn't give you rights to use it in Florida. But if you have a federal registration you have presumptive nationwide rights and it freezes the rest of the country in terms of their existing use of that mark.

### → **What if I plan to take my brand worldwide?**

Trademark rights are country-specific. And most countries are first to file rather than first to use meaning whomever files at the Trademark Office first can get superior rights. This means that it's important to have a strategy. It's very unlikely you will be able to file for everything, everywhere. Start with the countries and regions you're most likely to expand to and/or are notorious for trademark pirates.

### → **How can so many brands use the same name?**

Trademark rights are specific to the goods or services that you're using. Delta Air Lines and Delta Faucets is a good example. There's no likelihood of confusion because the goods/services offered by the two parties are completely different. Trademark rights are statutory and intended to protect the consumer. It means as a consumer you know the source of what you're buying. Functionally, it breaks down into trademark classes. If you have a restaurant, you still may be able to stop someone from selling a barbeque sauce because those could be considered related goods. Consumers now could expect a company to provide restaurant services and premade foods. Having a federal registration makes this easier to prove.

### → **Can you do a brief overview of trademark classes?**

The United States follows an international treaty. Most countries follow the same classification system. The system establishes 45 different classes. Classes 1-34 are for products. Classes 35-45 are for services. Generally the products within a class are lumped together based on their relatedness. For example, one class covers alcoholic beverages, excluding beer. Most clothing is covered by another

class. You have little-to-no control as a business owner over which class you fall into. Online, there is some wiggle room in terms of classification. For example, downloadable software is a product while online non-downloadable software is a service. Most countries accept really broad definitions of Goods and Services. The United States generally requires a higher level of specificity.

—————→ **Can you still find yourself in trouble even if you're legally in the right?**

Absolutely. Just like any other type of legal claim, just because someone alleges a wrongdoing, doesn't mean they are correct. There are "trademark bullies" that try to assert their trademark rights beyond that which they actually have—frequently against smaller companies. Or, you see smaller companies trying to do the same to larger companies who appear to have deep pockets. Unfortunately, until a mark has been registered for 5 years, a third party can challenge the registration owner's rights based on prior use.

—————→ **What are the best types of trademarks?**

Fanciful and Arbitrary Marks—these are made-up words and existing words used completely out of context. "Apple" is not protectable for fruit, but it's very protectable for computers. Similarly, made up words like Xerox are very strong.

From a marketing perspective, it takes a lot more time and money to get people to know it—escalator, thermos, trampoline – used to be trademarks. But over time their popularity turned them into generic words.

Suggestive Marks—these are marks that suggest something about the product or service but don't actually describe it. Greyhound for busses. Greyhounds are really fast dogs, so you assume the bus will be fast. Coppertone for suntan lotion is another suggestive mark. These names aren't as strong as Fanciful or Arbitrary marks, but they're generally solid.

Descriptive Marks—these are the weakest. These are marks that describe the products/services themselves or a characteristic of them. They're the hardest to protect because other people need to be able to describe what they do. If you've used a descriptive name for 5+ years and people have come to understand that designation as your product/service, you can strengthen your rights. Surnames and geographic indicators are also considered weak, although through extensive use (such as McDonalds for restaurants or Hilton for hotels) you can protect them.

Generic terms are not trademarks and not protectable—"Apple" for fruit, "Pencil" for writing instruments. In other words, if

it's the common commercial name for an item, it is not a trademark.

—————→ **What are things you can check on your own?**

You can search and access the USPTO database. It can be persnickety to use but you can find obvious conflicts pretty quickly. It can be complicated and esoteric, but it's a good place to start. The International Trademark Association may be of use as well. (inta.org) Legal counsel can be helpful in understanding what actually constitutes consumer confusion. Marks don't need to be identical to create confusion.

Factors for likelihood of confusion include: similarity of the marks themselves, relatedness of Goods and Services, similarity of channels of trade, conditions of purchase, how many other marks are out there on similar goods, and price point.

It is also useful to search the internet for your proposed name with your intended Goods & Services. It can be easy to find conflicts this way.

—————→ **How long does the registration process take? Can a name be safely used before the process is complete?**

In the United States you can file on actual use or intent to use. In most cases you

won't actually obtain a registration until you show use. How long it takes depends on if you have use but generally speaking, an application filed based on use that doesn't encounter any problems will register in 6–8 months.

—————→ **What happens when you file an application?**

You need to specify the Goods and Services on which you plan to use the mark. Within three to five months of filing the application, the Trademark Office will see if you meet all the basic requirements. If they have any issues, they issue what's called an Office Action. Then the applicant has six months to reply. You can either comply, modify or state your argument. If you're successful, the mark is approved and published for opposition. The mark remains open for 30 days for opposition by anyone who feels that they might be harmed by your registration. If it's not opposed, and the trademark is in use, a registration could issue within six to eight months. If it's based on intent to use the mark, a "notice of allowance" is issued and you have six months to three years to begin to use the mark. If your application is based on your intent to use the mark, you stop the clock by filing the application, meaning that if someone else files after you, you still have the first shot at registration and once you obtain

registration, your rights will date back to your filing date.

### → Heads up

In trademark there are only shades of gray—that is to say, there is almost no certainty to be had. It's just good to know who's out there and do what you can to avoid some trouble down the road. If you need help finding a trademark attorney, check out: [ahundredmonkeys.com/dc.it](http://ahundredmonkeys.com/dc.it). Ask them to give you an example of a trademark report so you know what you're paying for. Usually they will rate preliminary results with an A-through-F or 1, 2, 3 grading system.

After getting the trademark results back, assess your appetite for risk and select the passing names accordingly. Like I said, there are no “sure bets” in the trademark world so you should probably draw primarily from the “A” category unless you're unfazed by the threats presented for other names in the trademark report.

### → **Cultural screening**

Cultural screening is an essential component of the diligence process if you're operating internationally. Depending on your audience, it can also be useful domestically. If you plan to do

business only in your country (and have a solid grasp of the languages spoken there) it isn't explicitly necessary. The most important element of cultural screening is being clear about what you're screening. A lot of people enter this process hoping that their name conveys some sort of meaning globally. This is a fool's errand. The primary goal of cultural screening is not to offend or insult your audience. A quick Google search for “cultural brand screening” yields a bunch of companies who can help you screen your name internationally. Cultural screening is typically fairly affordable and priced per market screened. This means that screening a list of 20 names often (but not always) costs the same as screening one name.

A lot of people go overboard with cultural screening and try to clear names in every country on our little blue planet. This is counterproductive. Stick to countries you're sure you'll be operating in. Plenty of brands change their names in specific markets if they run into cultural issues down the road. This is particularly common in China. For example, BMW in China is called “Bǎomǎ” (宝马) which means Treasured Horse.

If you run into cultural conflicts, be pragmatic about it. If your name is

insulting or embarrassing, consider another option. If it sounds close to a word that might be negative, so what? Plenty of words in English sound similar to other words with negative associations. Screening companies are paid to find conflicts, so just because something shows up, doesn't mean it's a serious threat. Try to confirm your suspicions with locals you trust.

### → **Final contenders**

Get down to some final contenders. The goal at this point is to have three to five names in contention. If you have too many:

This is a good problem to have. Think about which names differentiate you the most from the competition. Think about which names get the biggest reaction out of people. Instead of asking them how they feel about a name, just say, "I'm starting a [blank] called [blank]." Don't ask. Just tell and gauge their reaction. A lot of people are really good at reading facial expressions and vocal intonation to see how you feel about something before chiming in. Tell them the name with confidence, not like you're asking for permission. Writing out the answer to "Why is your company called [blank]?" can be helpful too. If there's a strong connection and an interesting story, you're probably headed in the right direction.

If you have too few:

If you have too few names at this point, chances are the names you came up with are already taken. Go back to your big list of names and look into some of your more wild options. Revisit the New species discovered daily chapter and explore some more categories. Check out our lists resource here: [ahundredmonkeys.com/dc.it](http://ahundredmonkeys.com/dc.it). Think of it as an excuse to be a little more daring.

If you're planning on registering for trademark, now is the time to take your best name(s) to a trademark attorney for registration.

Remember, while picking an interesting name might feel a little risky right now, six months down the road it won't feel like a risk at all. An interesting name is the best way to ensure that the people who come in contact with your brand will remember you and want to engage with you. Boring and descriptive names are actually very risky because they don't make you think and are hard to remember. So please, don't take the risk of picking a boring name.

Eli Altman is Creative Director at the Berkeley, California-based naming company A Hundred Monkeys. He has led hundreds of naming projects from Silicon Valley startups to the products of Fortune 50 companies. He was responsible for developing the naming process at A Hundred Monkeys and previously at MetaDesign, San Francisco. Eli started naming before he stopped wearing Velcro shoes. He took his first paid naming job at 16 when he felt his voice was deep enough to “sound like an adult.” He lives in Oakland, California with his wife, Allie and dog, Davis.

@elialtman

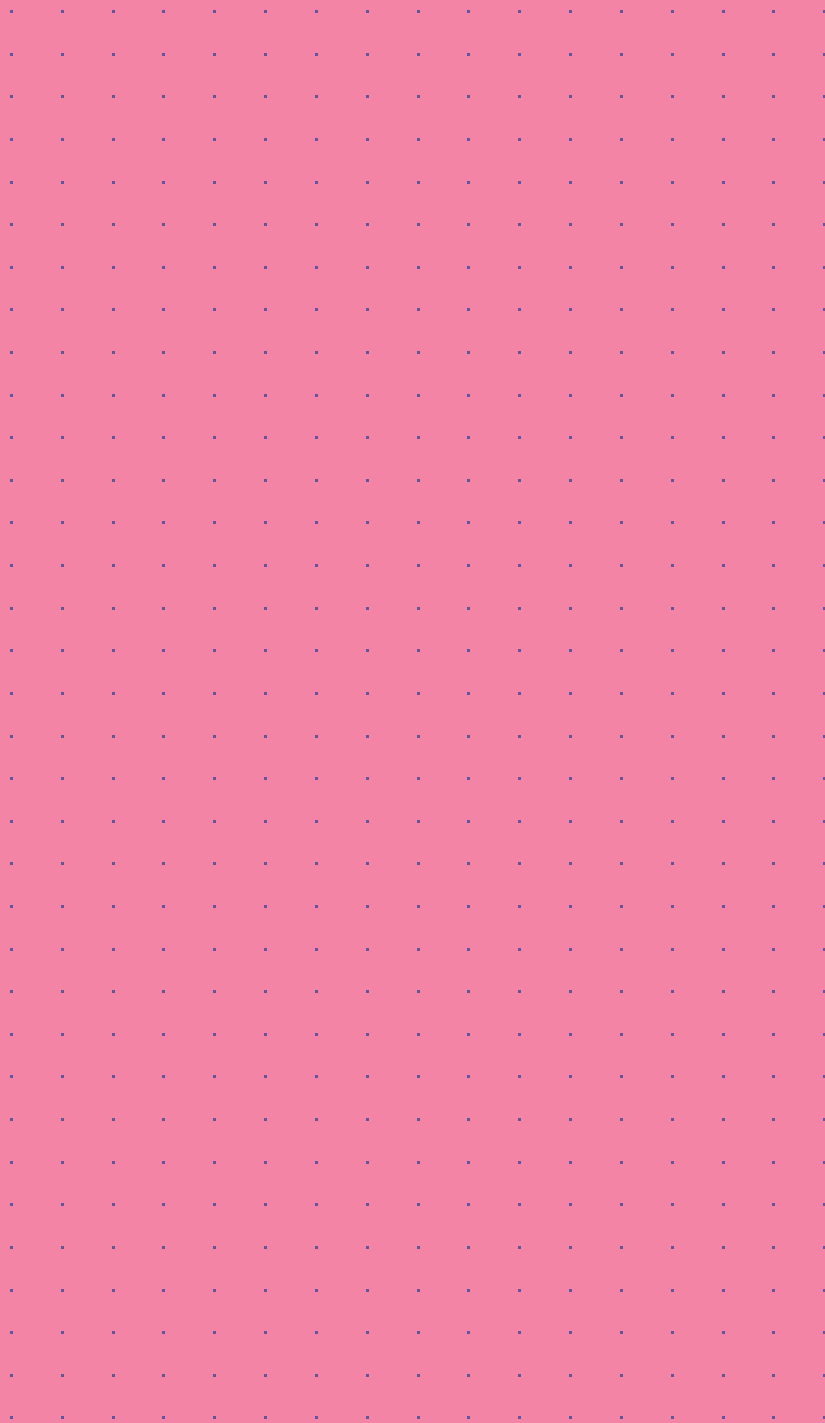
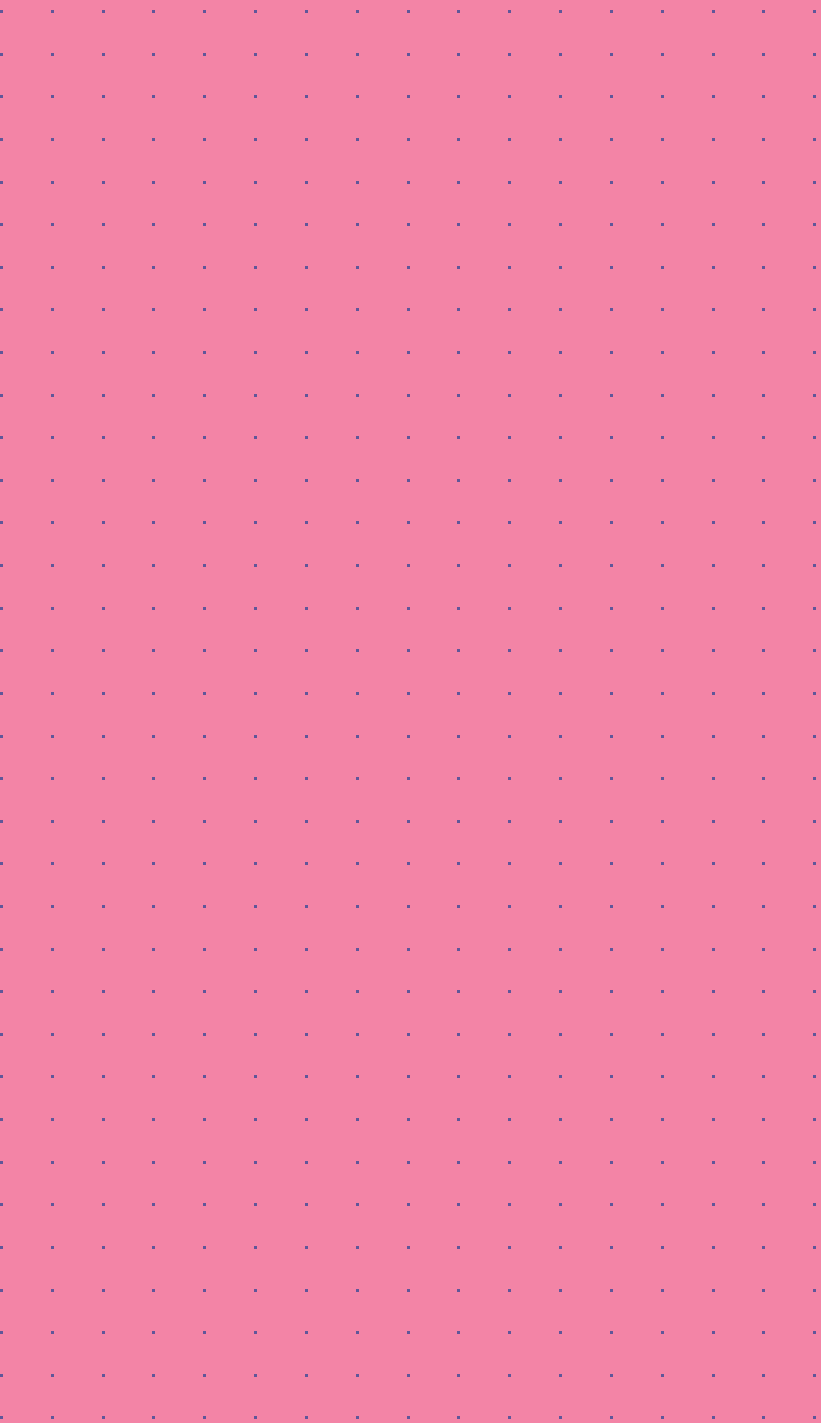
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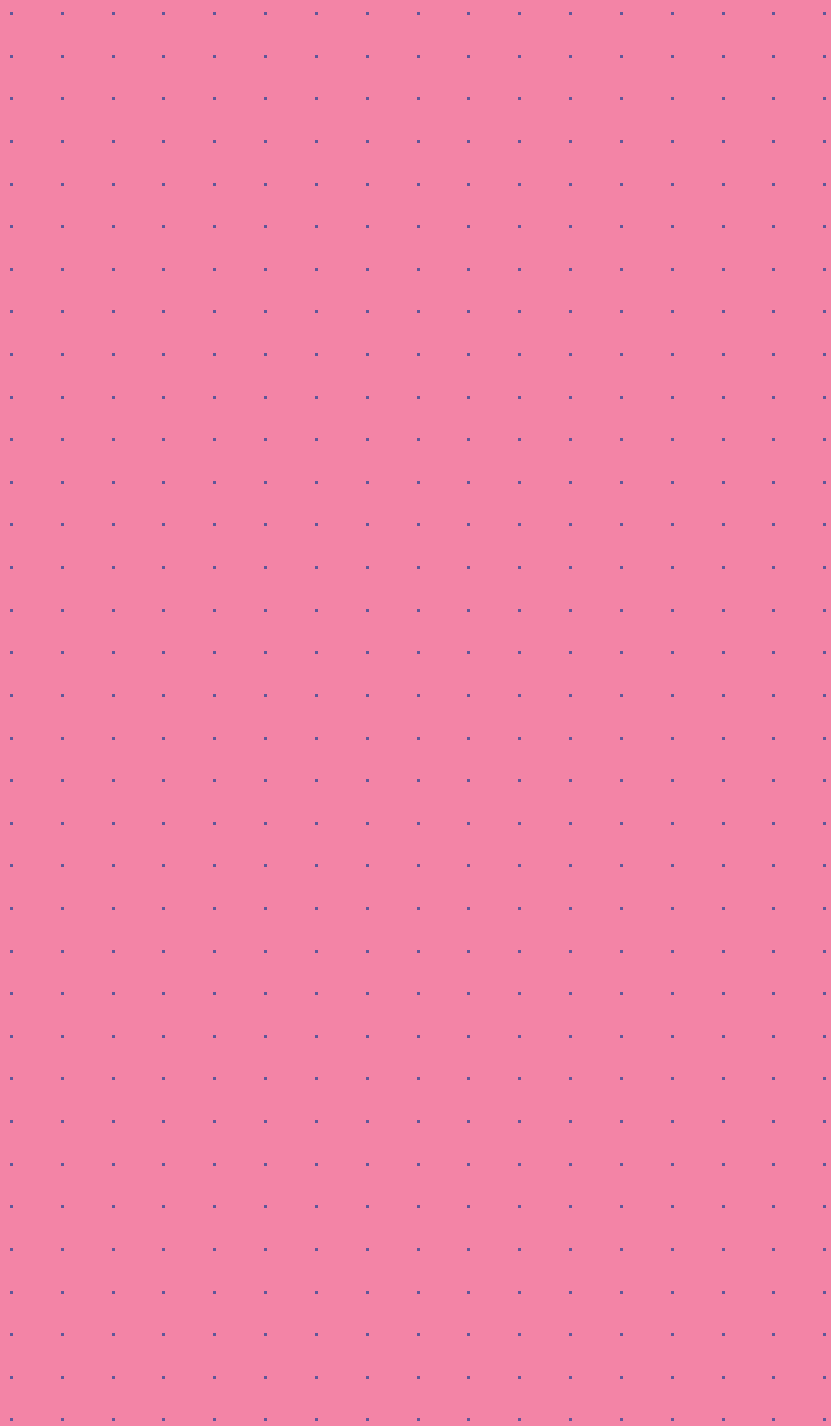
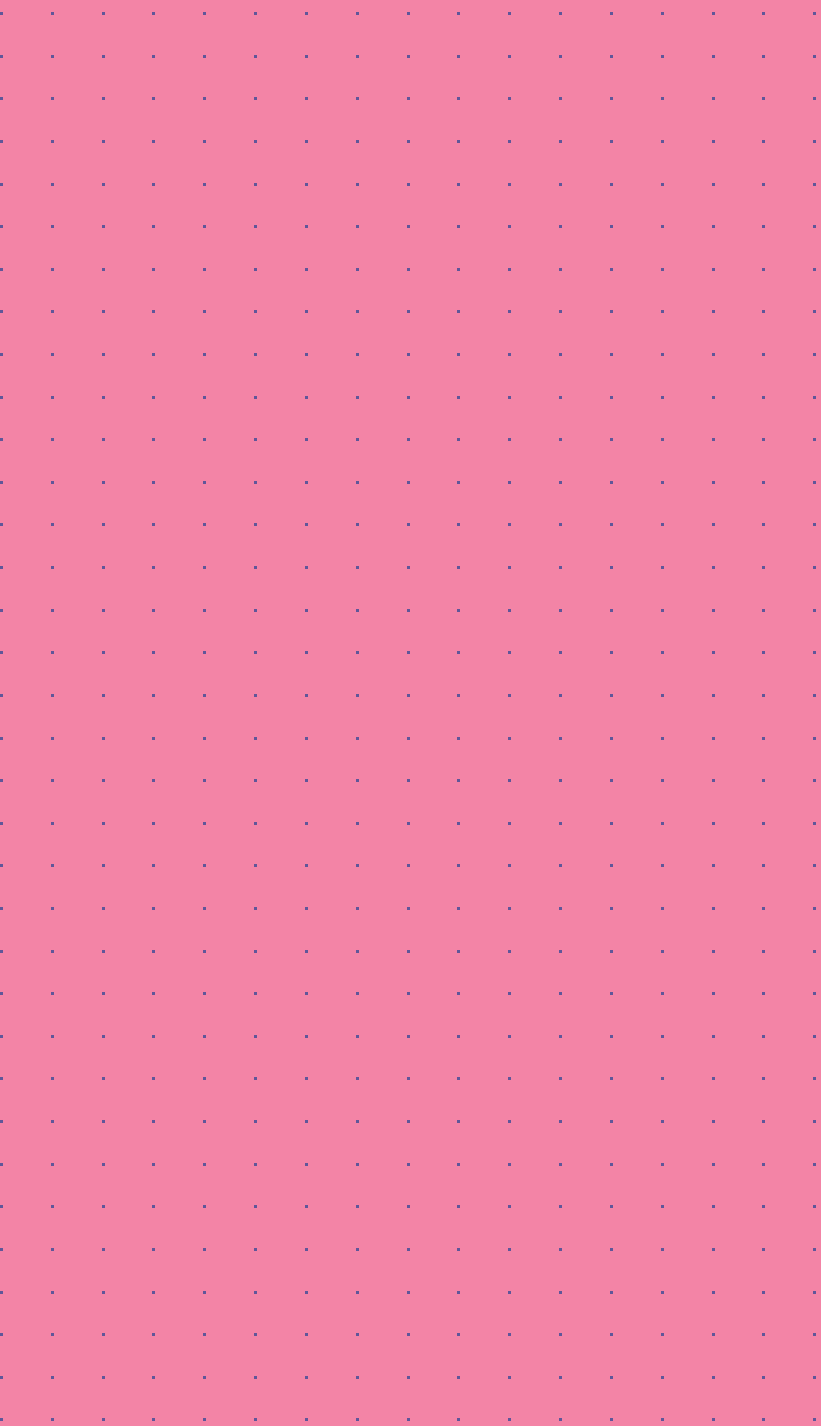


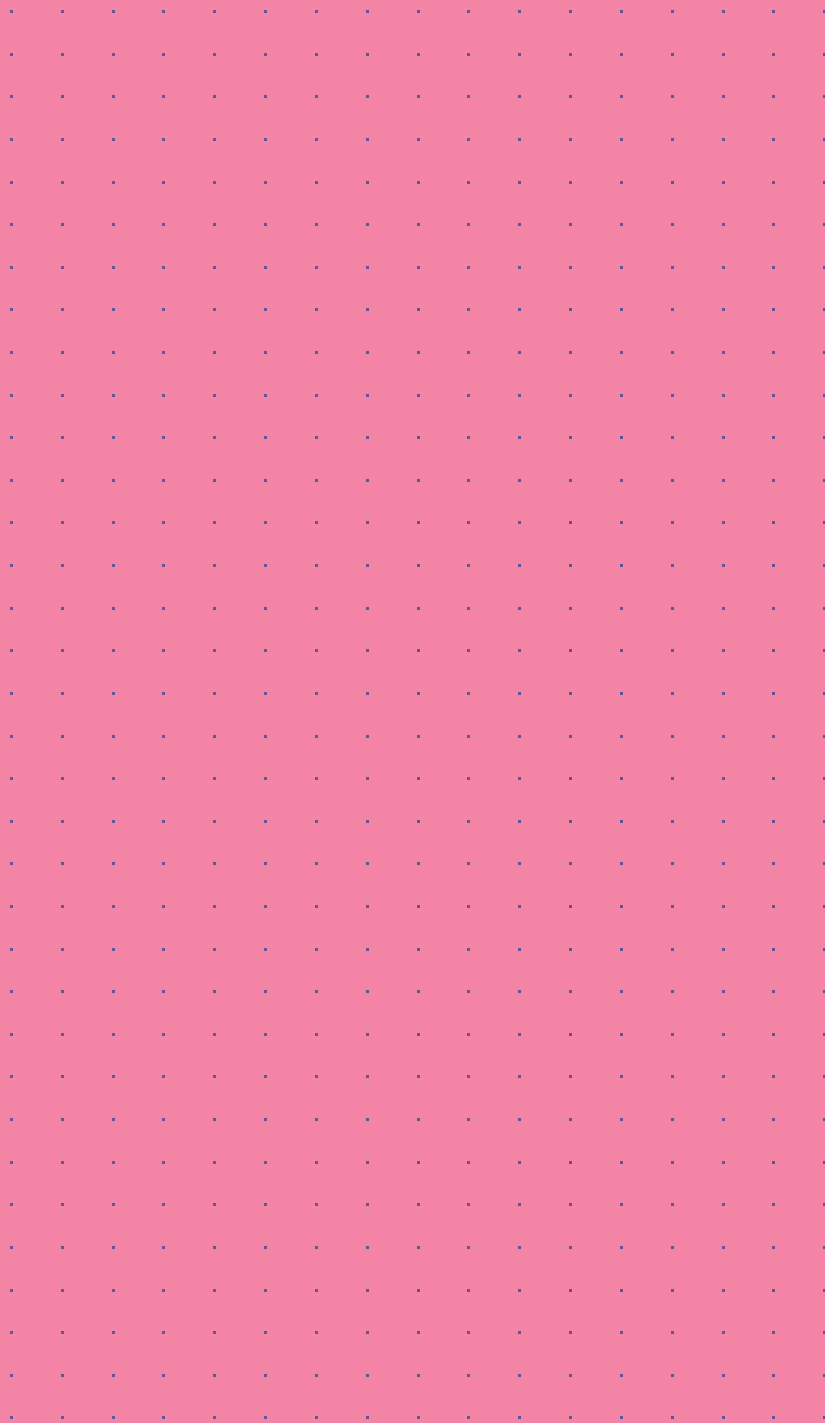
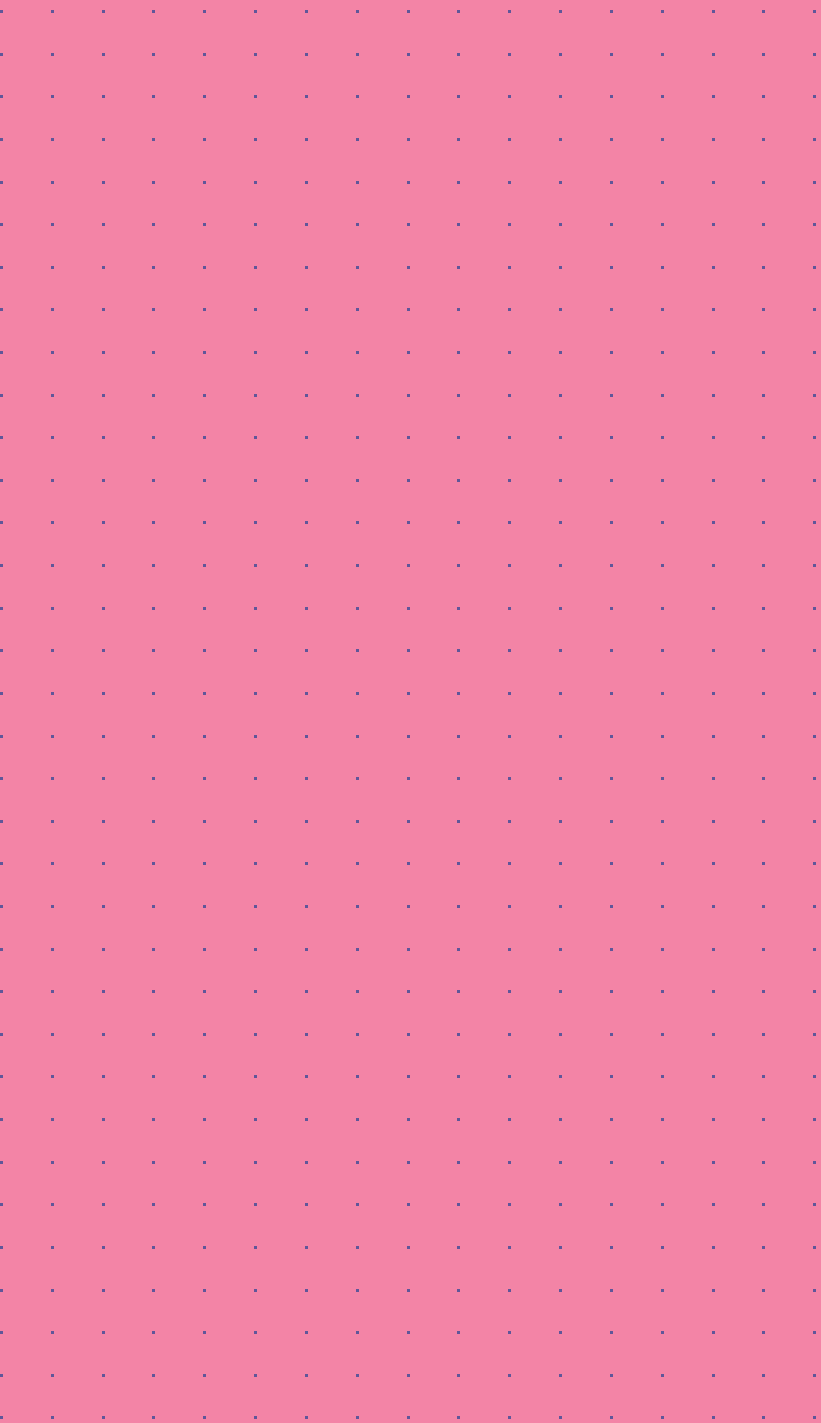


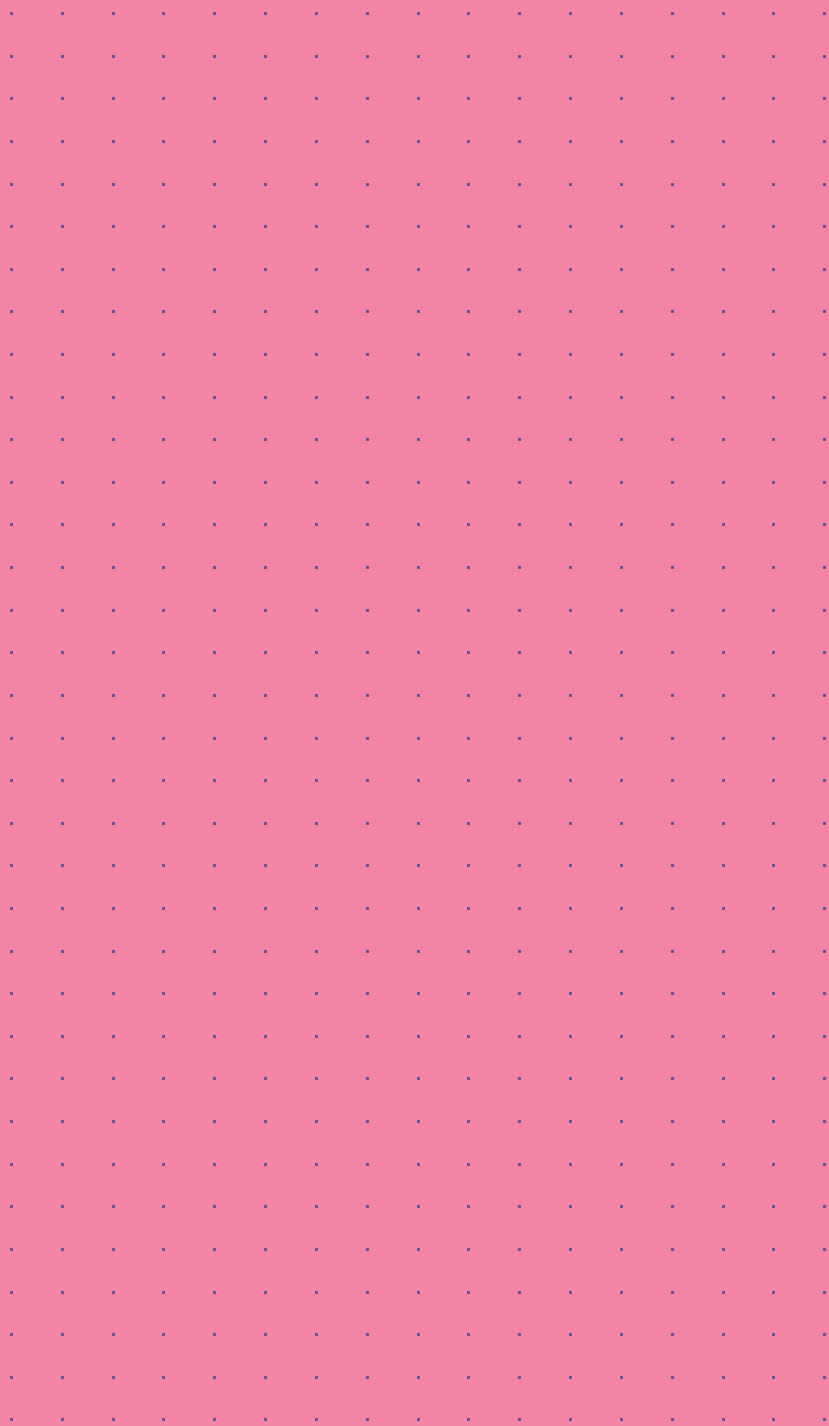
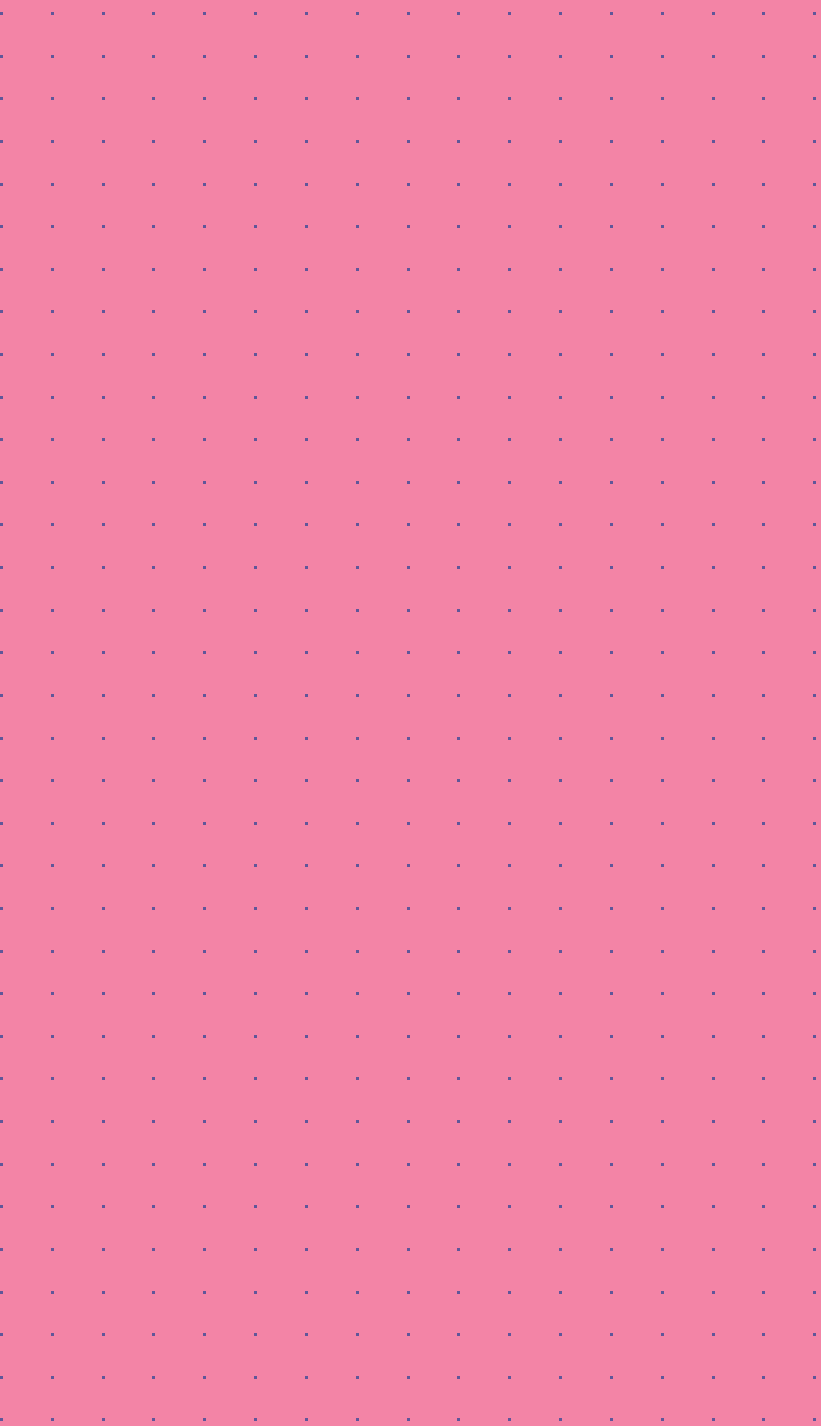




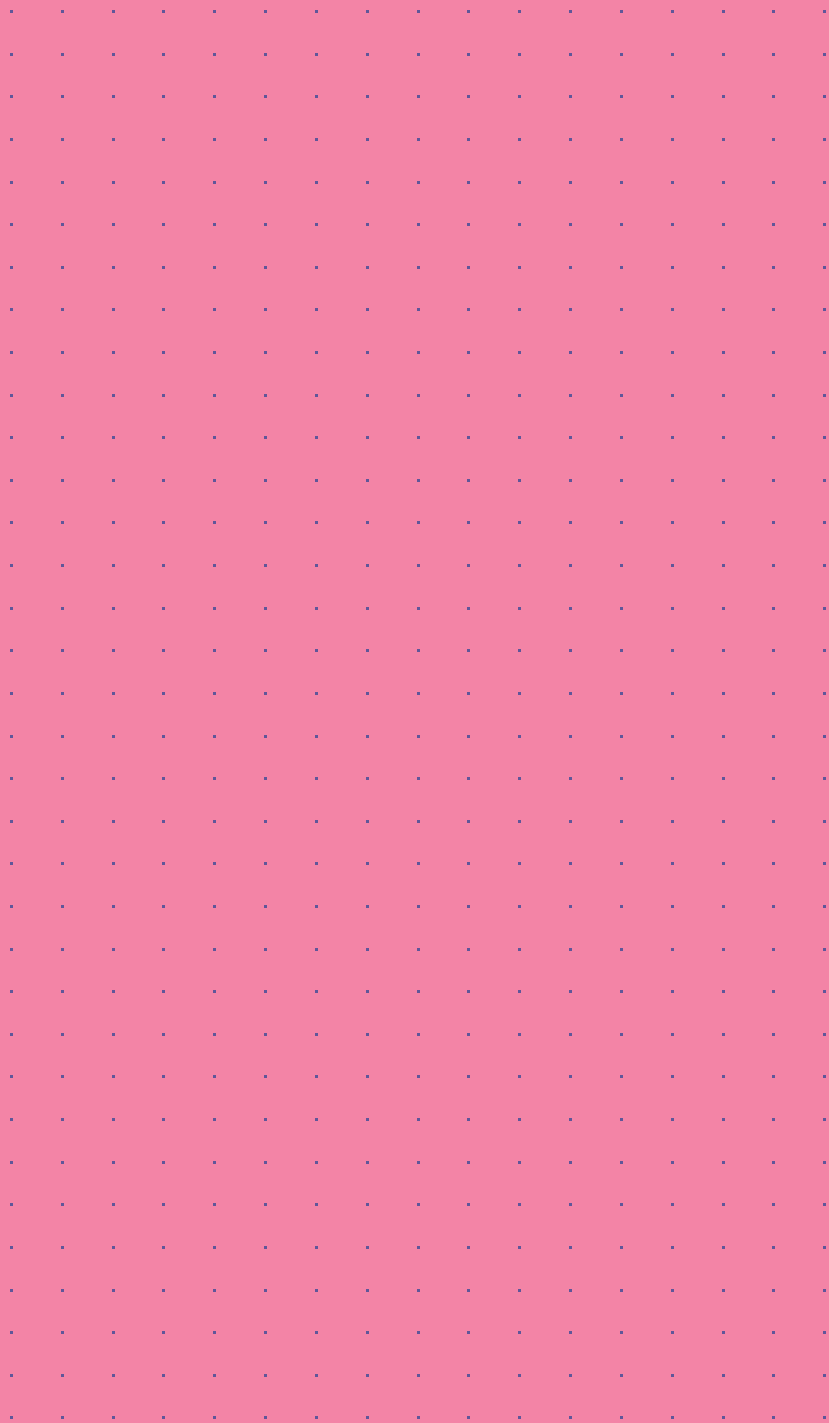
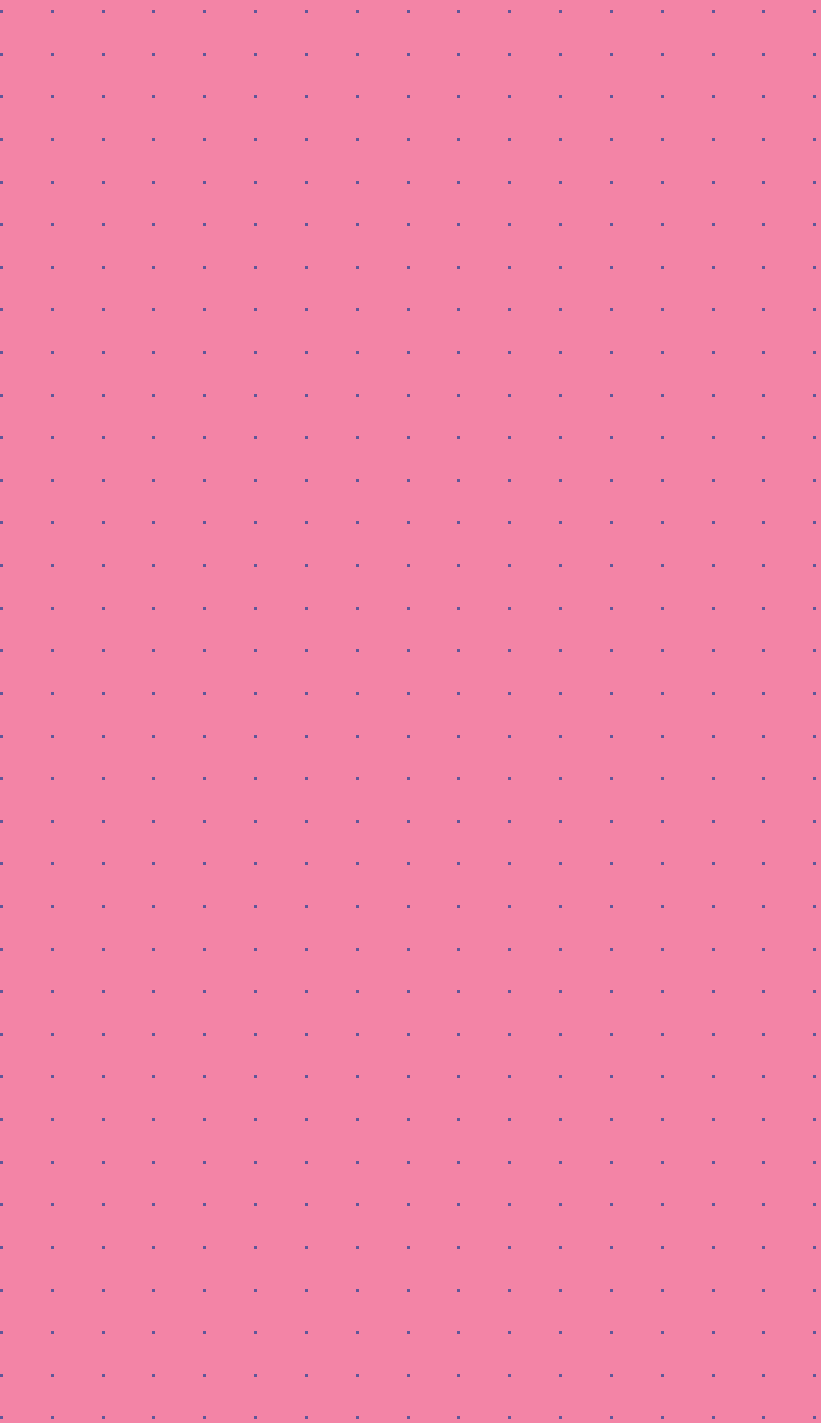


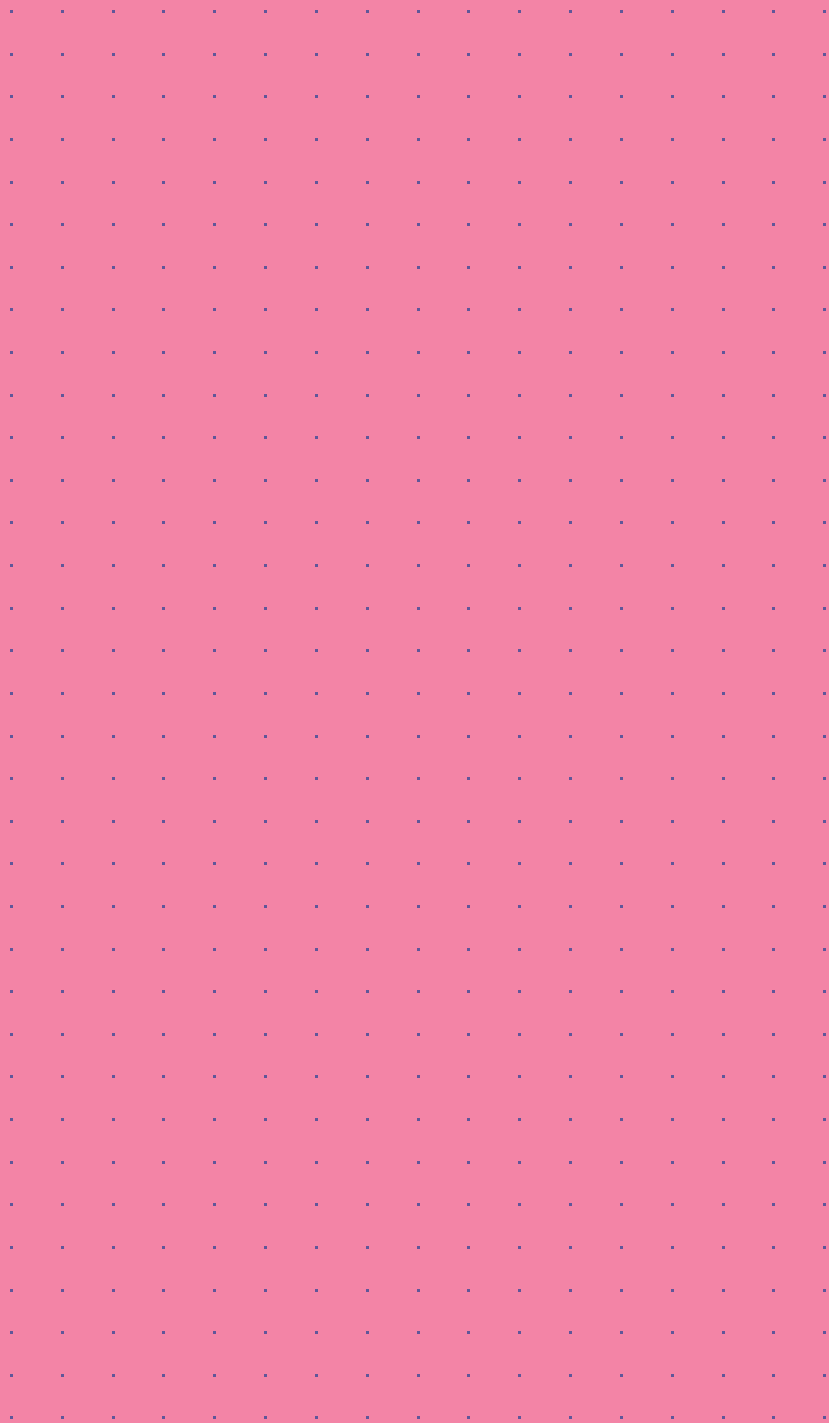
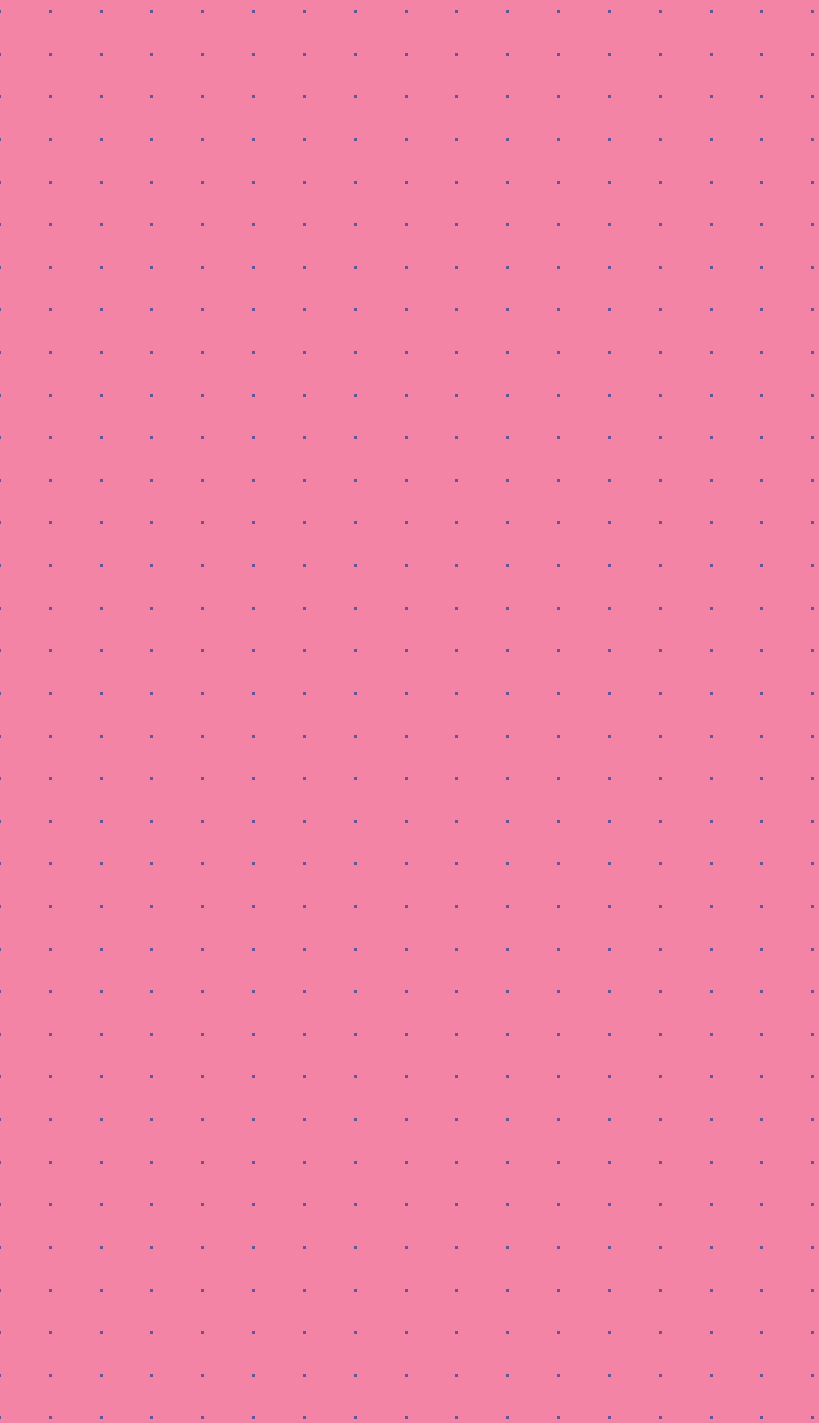




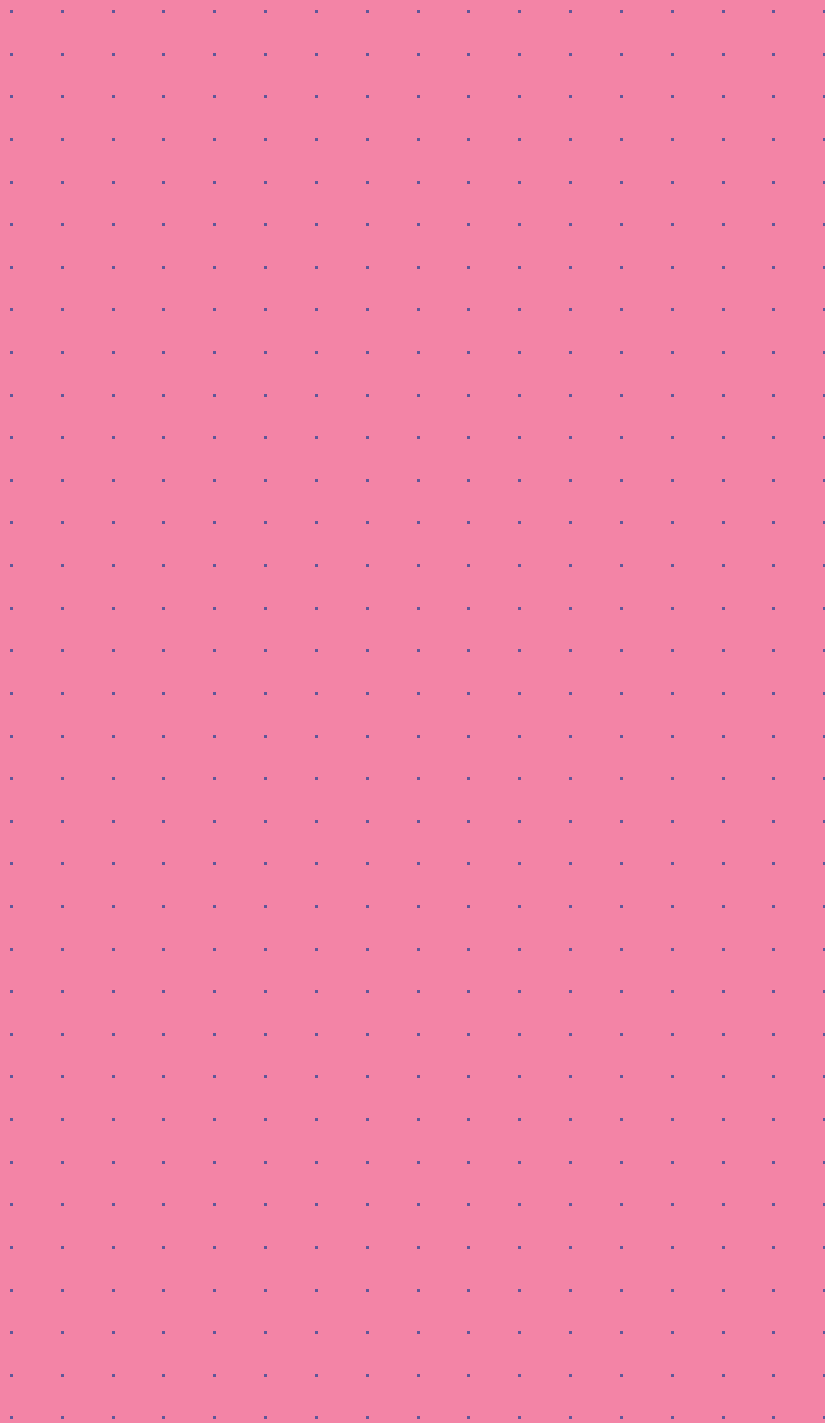
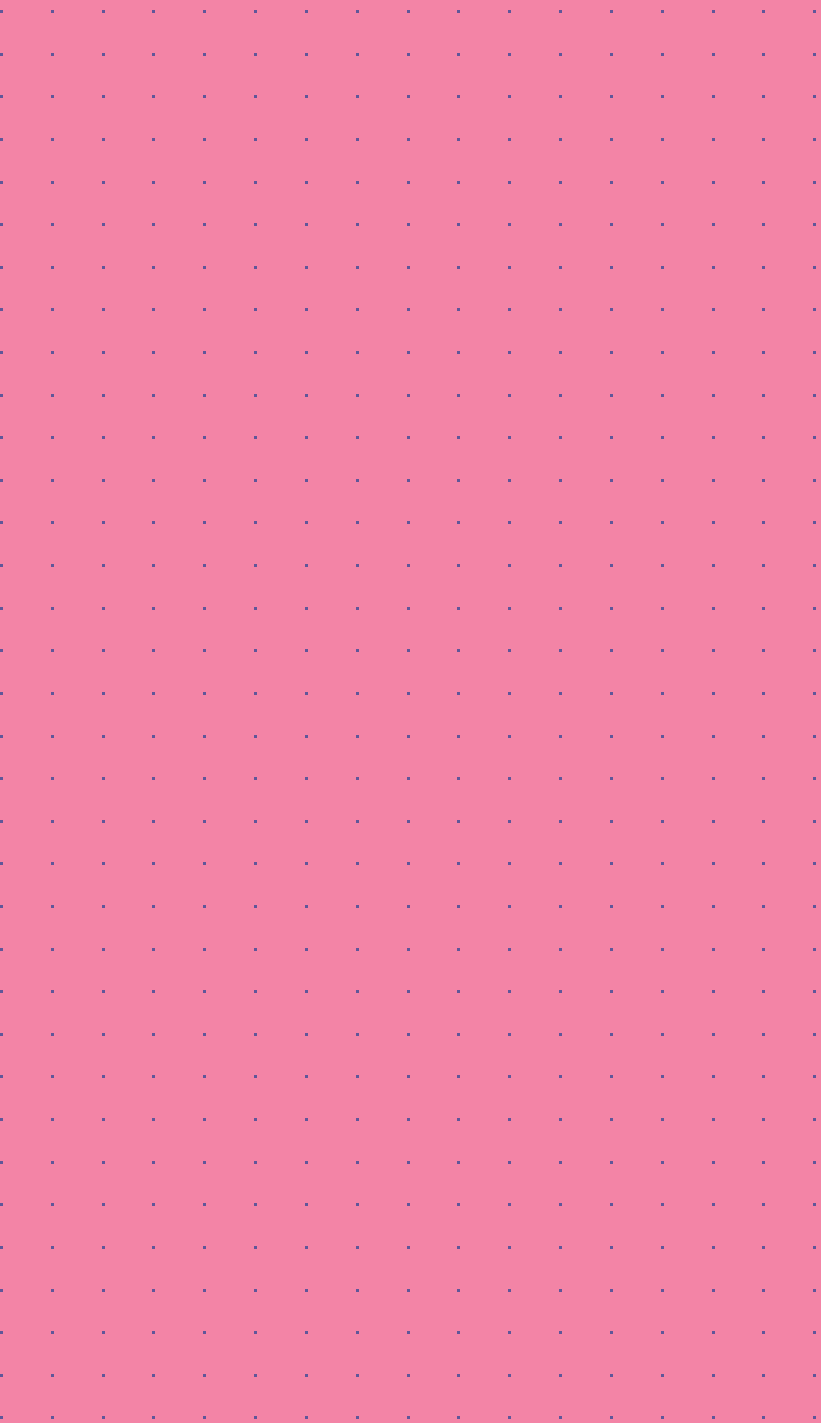


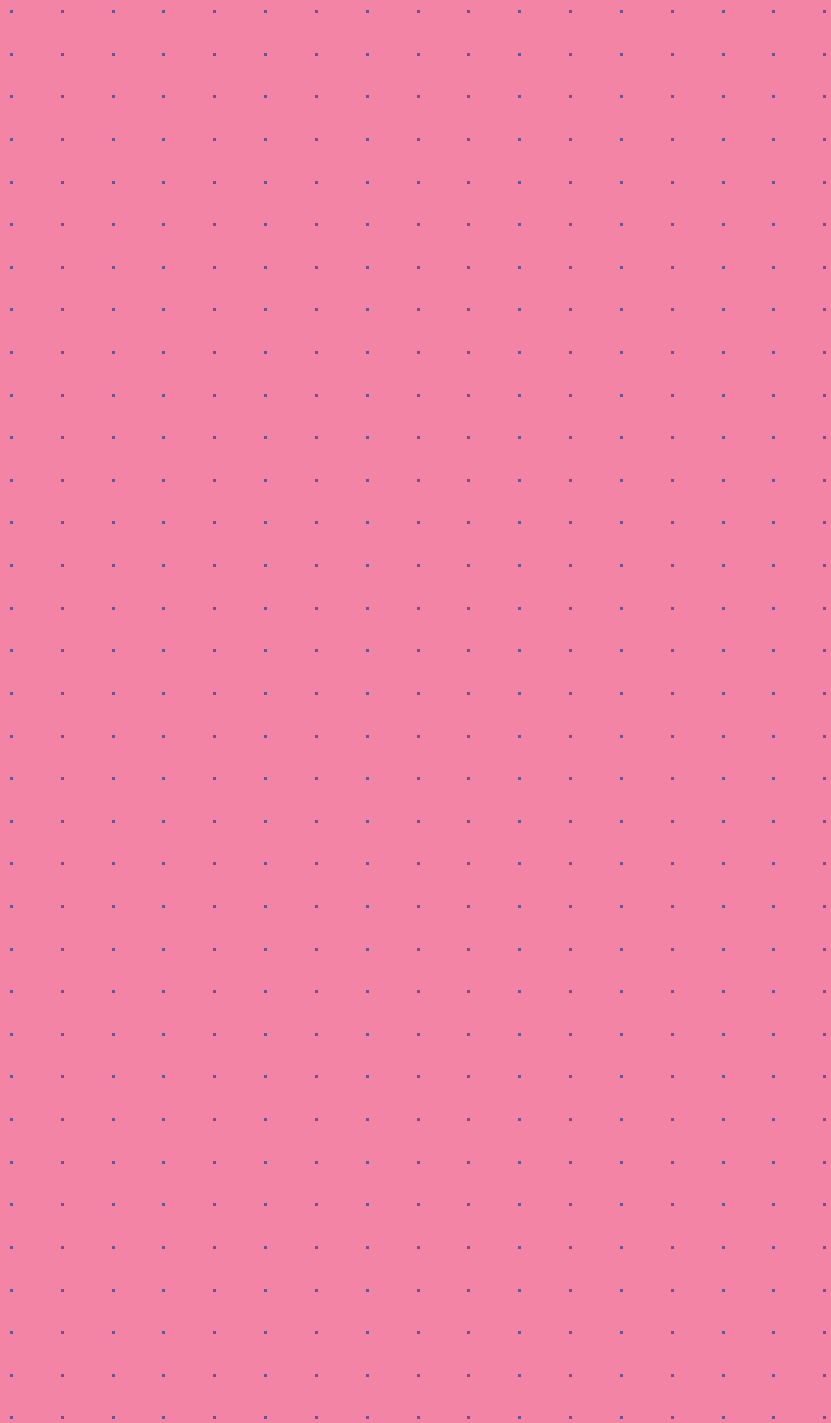
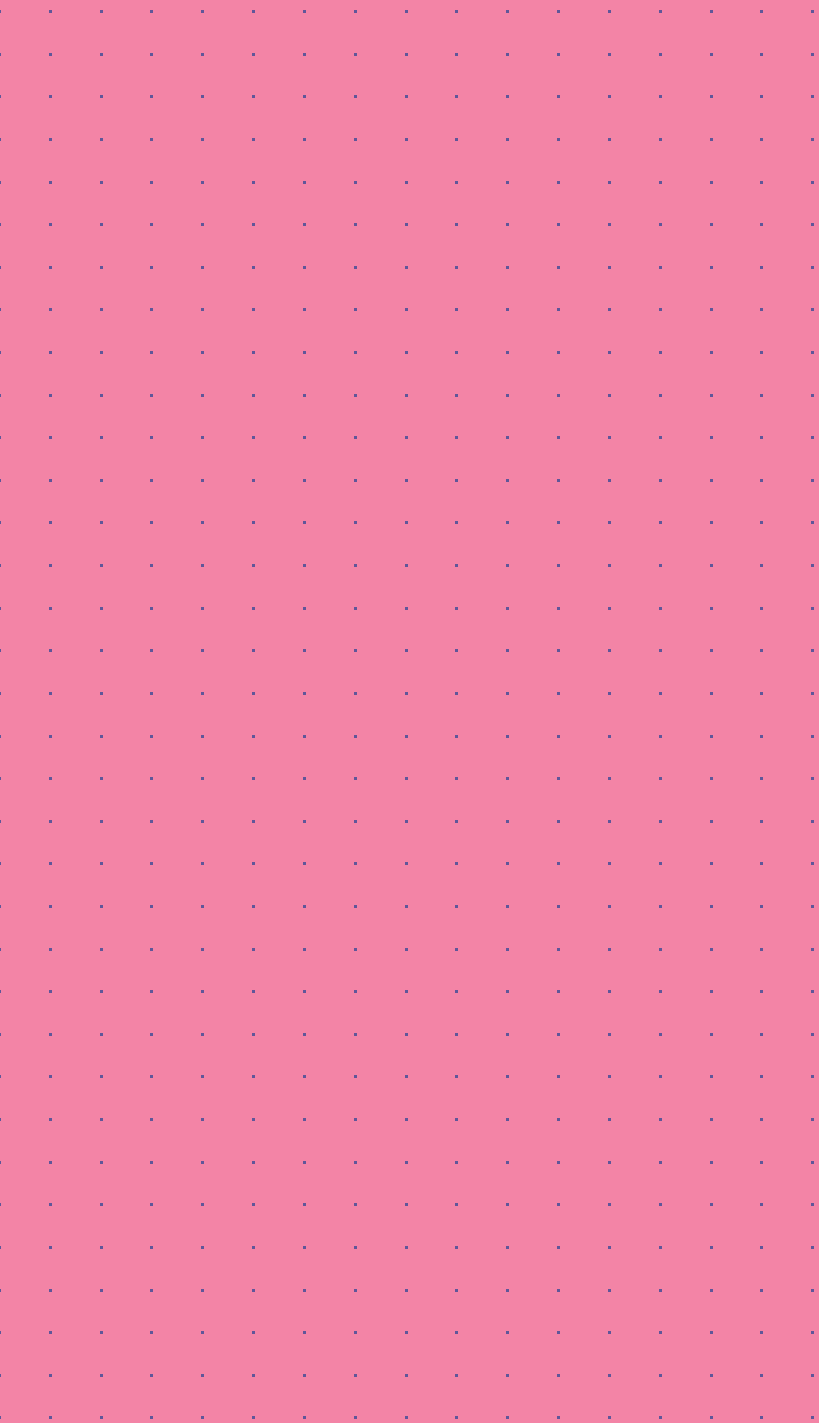


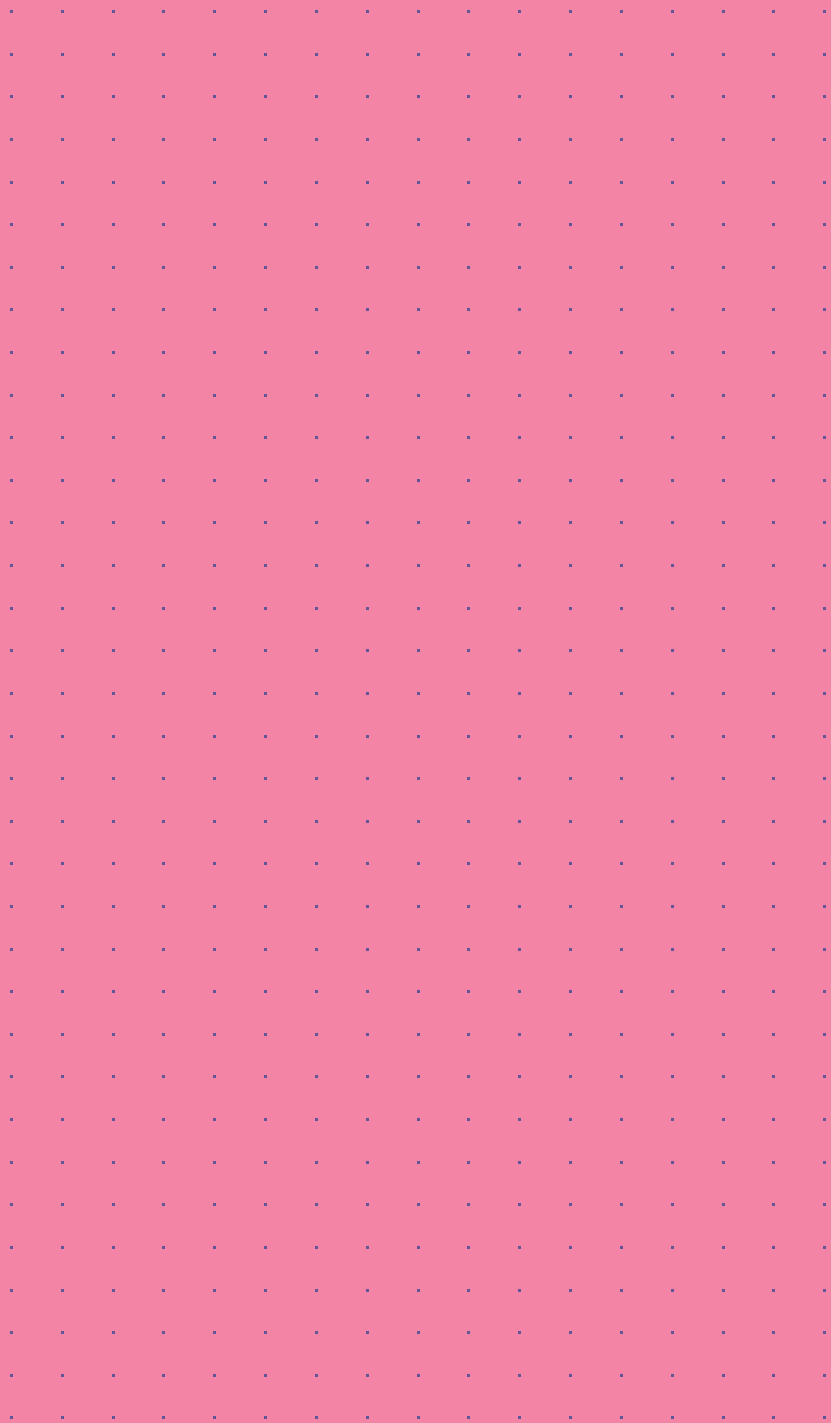
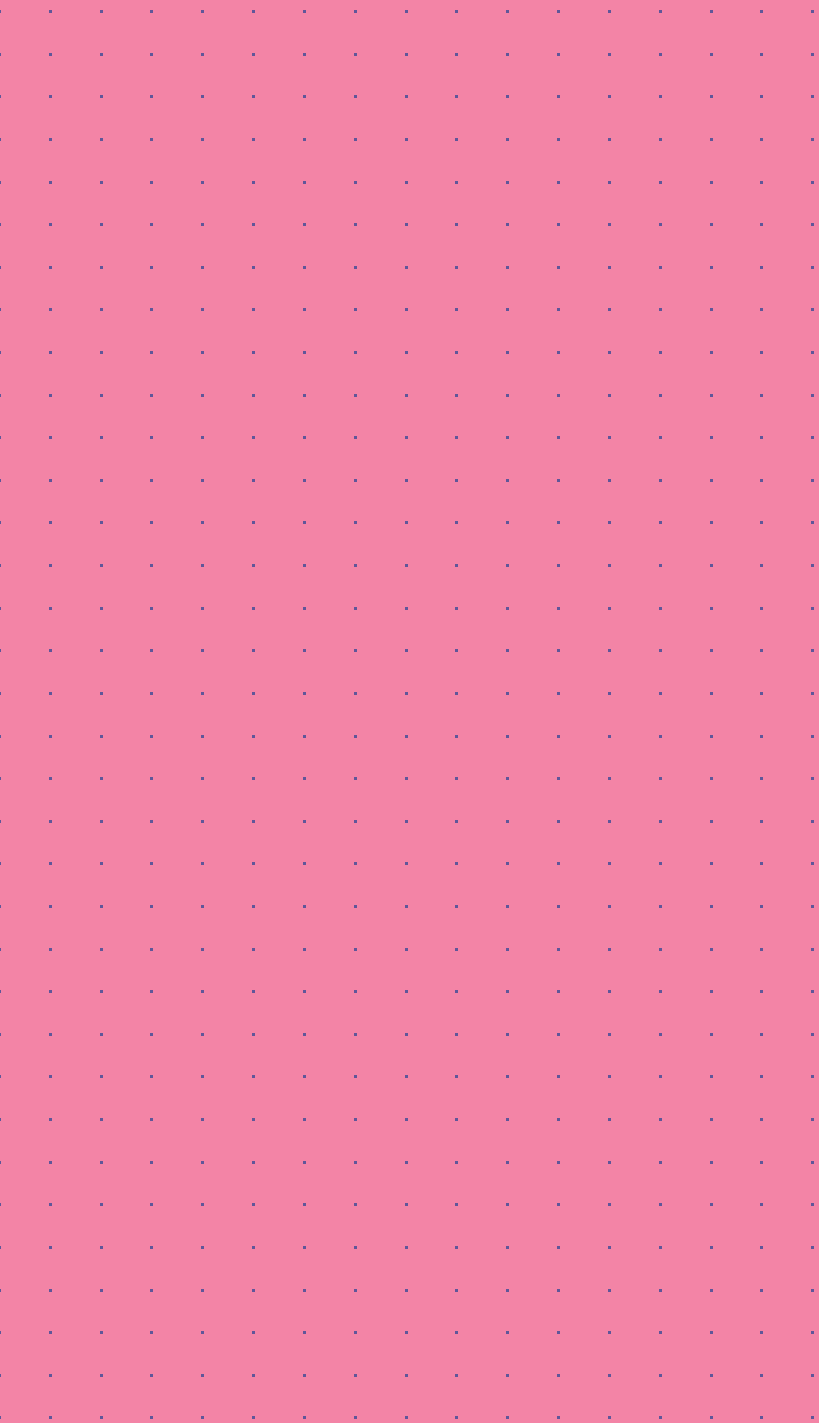


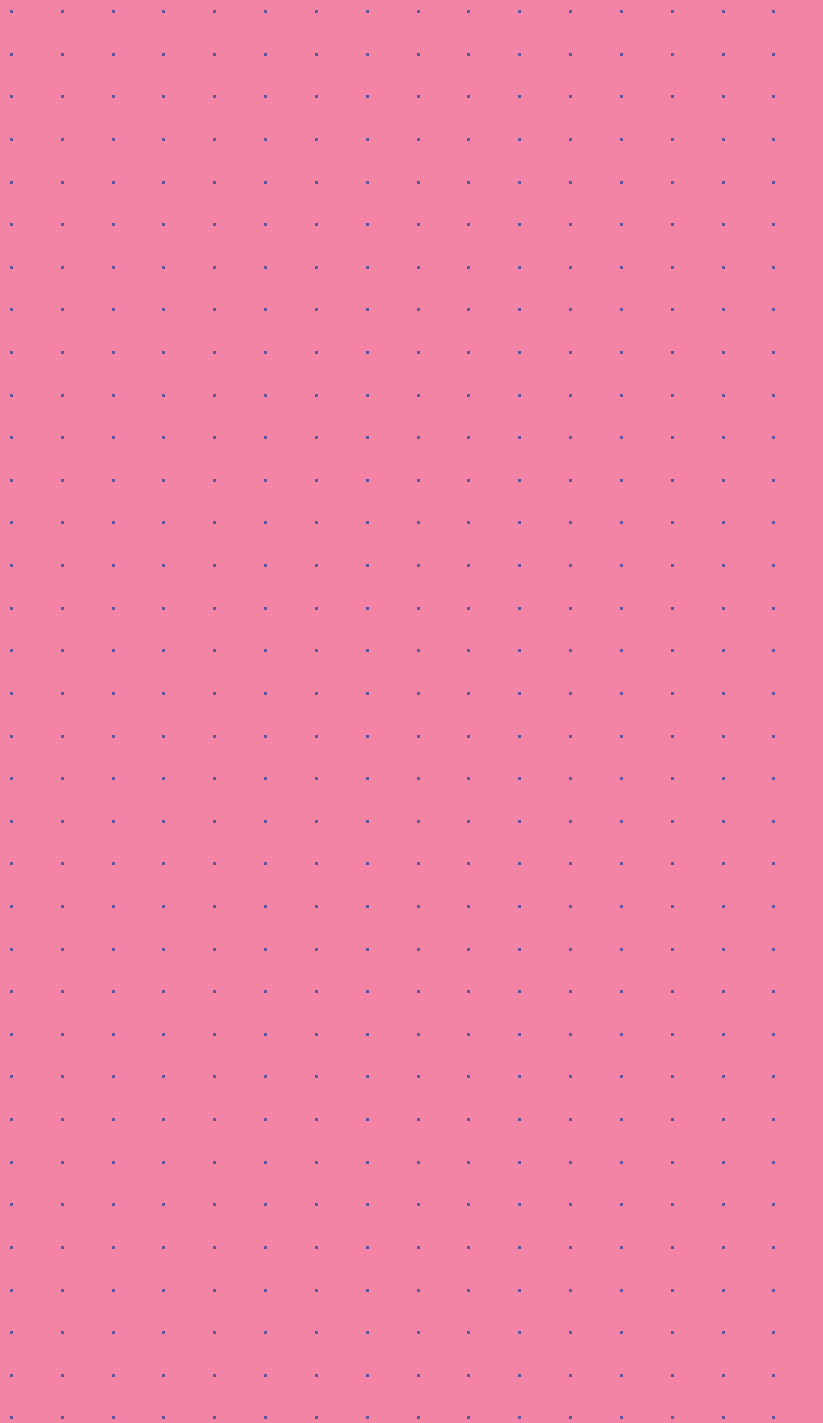
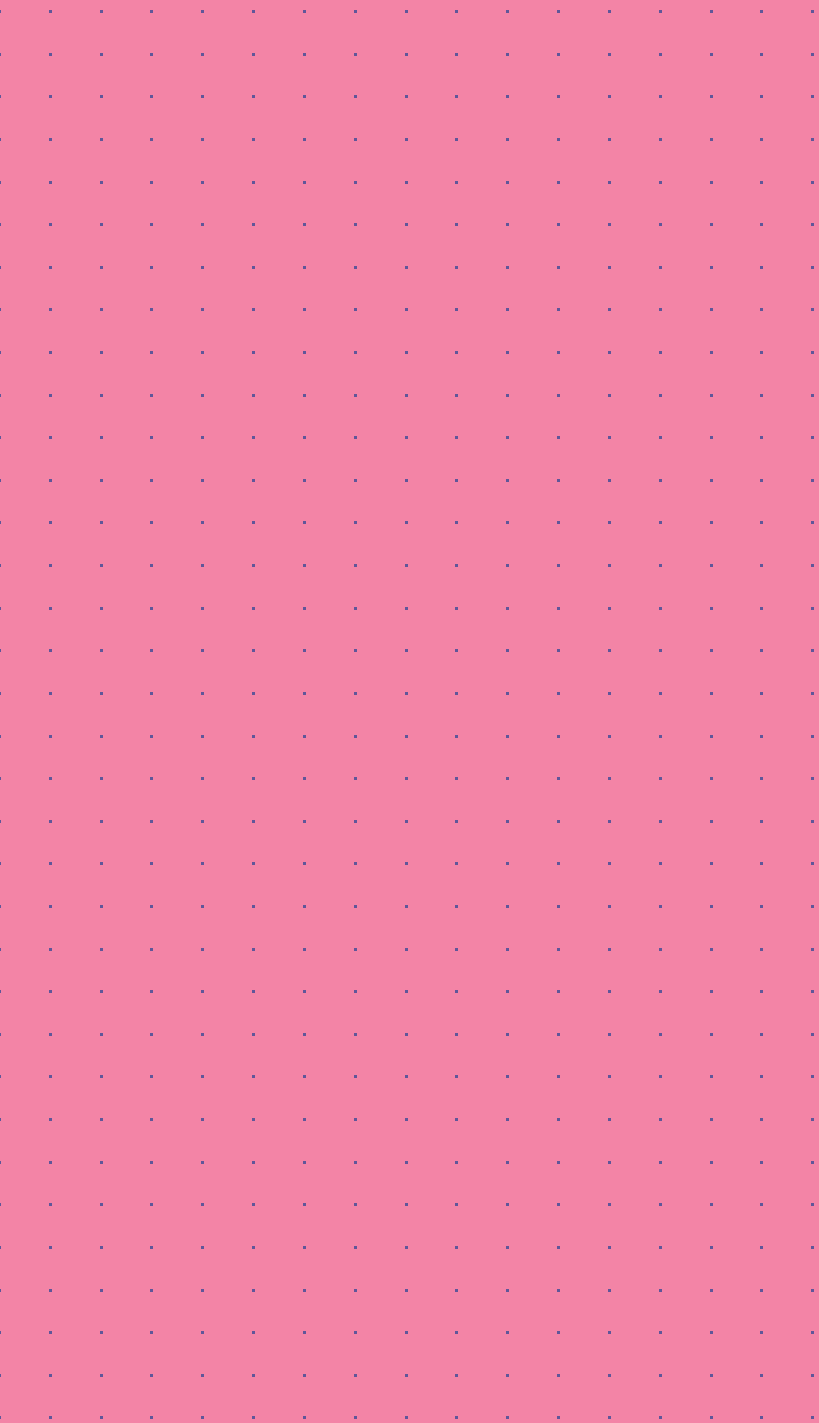












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